

OM NANDURKAR

**BEFORE
I COULD
SAY I
LOVED
YOU**

A NOVEL

Try Kelyani Sarva Hote....

PART ONE

Chapter 1

Amidst the Noise

The city of Pune stood proudly beneath the warm glow of the afternoon sun. Known as the "Oxford of the East," Pune had a way of blending its rich history with the ever-expanding horizons of modernity. Ancient forts stood guard over the bustling streets, while the shadows of monuments like Shaniwar Wada and Aga Khan Palace whispered stories of the past. The air, filled with the aroma of vada pavs and freshly brewed chai, carried the dreams of millions who roamed its streets.

Among its many charms, Pune boasted a unique sense of life, an energy that echoed from the young crowd who thrived in its educational institutions. Students from all over the country, brimming with aspirations, arrived to craft their futures here. The city was alive, each corner humming with the rhythm of daily life, yet there was always room for solitude—a kind of peace amidst the chaos.

Pune's lifeline, the Pune Municipal Transport (PMT), threaded through the city's heart like veins. PMTs carried the city's spirit—an unassuming yet vital force that connected every neighborhood, from the old city of Peths to the upscale regions of Koregaon Park. These buses were packed with passengers, each lost in their own world, standing shoulder to shoulder, yet miles apart. People glued

to their phones or listening to music, isolated from the hum of the crowd around them.

On one such bus, rattling through Pune's streets, stood Rahul—pressed against the cold metal wall, the crowd's invisible hands shoving him deeper into the bus. The AC vents blasted frigid air, which made Rahul feel sick. He hated it. Every day, the cold, stale air made his stomach churn, and each ride on the PMT became an ordeal. Yet, he had no choice. It was the only affordable way to travel to RaiChand College of Engineering, where Rahul was in his fourth year of computer engineering.

The PMT wobbled as it halted at the next stop. Rahul, standing at the rear, stared at the exit, his mind focused on the struggle of getting out. With every passing second, more people crowded in, their bodies pressed against his. The PMT was packed to the brim, and every stop was a battle of wills. As the bus jerked forward, Rahul braced himself against the window, gritting his teeth. His college was just around the corner. He could already feel the anxiety rising, as it did every day. The PMT screeched to a stop, and Rahul squeezed through the crowd, shouting, "Stop!" as the bus resumed its journey. The driver glanced back, indifferent, but eventually halted long enough for Rahul to stumble out.

Outside, the city blared its horns at him—impatient cars, irritated bikers. Rahul merely sighed and walked towards his college, his expression calm, as though none of the chaos around him even registered. It was his routine. The traffic, the shouting—it was all just noise.

RaiChand College of Engineering was one of Pune's reputed institutions. Rahul entered the campus quietly, unnoticed by the crowd of students that buzzed in the corridors. His footsteps echoed in the hallway, though no one seemed to care. He preferred it that way—Rahul was the type who could be invisible in a room full of people.

At first glance, you might think Rahul was shy, maybe even socially awkward. But he wasn't. He could talk, and talk well if he wanted to. But he didn't. He chose silence, preferred it even. Confidence lay beneath his exterior, but he kept it hidden, speaking only when necessary. Most people didn't understand him, so they labeled him as an introvert or a loner. He let them.

He was of average height, around 5'7 or 5'8, with fair skin and brown eyes that seemed to observe everything without letting on too much. His hair was thick, neatly combed, and he dressed simply—jeans, a plain t-shirt, and sneakers. Nothing about him stood out, except for the subtle confidence he carried within.

As Rahul entered the classroom, five minutes late, the professor threw him a glance but let him sit without saying anything. Rahul found his usual spot at the back corner of the room, quietly settling down as the lecture continued. His mind drifted as he arranged his notes, barely paying attention to the professor's monologue about some Computing Class.

"Rahul," the professor's voice snapped. "You're late, sitting in the back, and not even paying attention. Stand up."

The room fell silent, heads turning toward Rahul. The professor didn't even wait for a response before launching into a tirade. *"This is exactly the kind of behavior that leads to failure. You come late, you sit in the back, and you don't pay attention. Are you even capable of learning?"*

The words didn't sting. Rahul knew the answer to the professor's question. He knew the topic, understood it even better than most in the room, but there was no point in speaking up. The professor wasn't interested in hearing from him. So, Rahul stayed quiet, letting the professor's frustration flow over him like water.

After a few more moments of scolding, the professor let him sit, and the class erupted in muffled laughter. Rahul didn't care. He ignored them, pulled out his book, and began taking notes, his face a mask of indifference.

When the lecture ended, Rahul gathered his belongings. Nitin, a classmate who sat a few rows ahead, approached him.

"Why didn't you answer the professor? You knew the answer, didn't you?" Nitin asked, half amused, half curious.

Rahul shrugged. *"It doesn't matter."*

Nitin raised an eyebrow. "Either you're too smart, or you don't care. I can't tell which."

"I've got work to do," Rahul said, brushing him off. It was a lie—he just didn't want to engage.

He left the classroom without another word. Rahul had been shuffled into this class recently due to new rules, so most people didn't know him well. It didn't bother him. He preferred the solitude.

Later that evening, Rahul found himself in the library. It was his refuge, a place where he could immerse himself in the world of history and ancient studies—the subjects that truly fascinated him, far more than engineering ever could. As he approached the librarian's desk with a stack of history books, the librarian intern—a girl around his age—gave him a small smile. She had noticed Rahul before, quiet and distant, but not dumb.

"He's definitely not dumb," she said to a colleague nearby, watching him from the corner of her eye.

Rahul, oblivious to her attention, took the receipt without a word and left. He had no intention of small talk.

The sun was beginning to set, and Rahul's stomach grumbled in protest. It was the end of the month, and he hadn't eaten lunch today—his wallet was nearly empty. The thought of taking the PMT

back home made his stomach churn, so he decided to walk instead.

As he made his way through the city, lost in thought, his phone rang. It was his father.

"How are you, beta?" his father asked.

"Good, Papa," Rahul replied, his voice calm. He could hear the concern in his father's voice.

"Studies going well?"

"Yeah, they're fine."

There was a pause on the other end. *"Do you have enough money?"*

Rahul hesitated. He didn't, but asking his father for more wasn't an option. His father had already sacrificed so much, working hard to keep the family afloat. "I'm fine, Papa," Rahul said softly.

The call ended, and Rahul's thoughts drifted. He hadn't wanted to be an engineer. His heart had always leaned towards the arts—history, geography, the stories of ancient times. But this was the path laid out for him, and he couldn't veer from it.

The sky darkened as clouds gathered, and soon, rain began to pour. Rahul didn't mind. He kept walking, letting the rain soak him through. When he reached a large tree with a stone bench

wrapped around its base, he sat down. The rain fell harder, but Rahul remained there, lost in the storm both outside and within.

Chapter 2

Scarf in the Storm

The night had arrived in Pune, not with a sudden jolt, but with a gradual transition, as if the city itself hadn't noticed the shift from day to evening and from evening to night. The rain continued its rhythmic dance, unrelenting yet calming, a constant companion to the flickering streetlights that dotted the now-empty roads. The city that had been alive just hours ago, with its buzzing traffic, the sounds of honking horns, and the hurried pace of people trying to reach their destinations, had now retreated into a quiet lull. The shops and cafes that had once overflowed with chatter had closed their doors to the storm, offering warmth and light to those who sought refuge from the cold, wet world outside. The roads, usually crowded, now lay deserted, wet and reflective like a mirror beneath the rain, as though Pune itself had taken a deep breath and decided to rest for the night.

Amidst this serene yet lonely landscape sat Rahul, almost invisible against the massive trunk of the peepal tree. The tree, once a proud giant, now stood leafless and bare, its branches skeletal, stretching upwards like arms in a silent plea to the heavens. Rahul, soaked through to his skin, didn't move. He sat at the base of the tree, knees pulled tightly to his chest, arms wrapped around them in an attempt to keep the world at bay. The rain fell on him

relentlessly, each drop sliding down his hair, gathering at his brows, and finally clinging to his long, thick lashes before falling away again. The rain on his skin was cold, and yet he didn't feel it. His mind was elsewhere, lost in the labyrinth of thoughts that he so often wandered into.

The world around him had disappeared, replaced by the familiar territory of his thoughts, a place where the passing of time held no meaning. He barely noticed the fact that his clothes were drenched, clinging to him uncomfortably, or that the tree he was sitting under offered no protection from the storm. His breaths came slow and shallow, so quiet that it seemed as if he wasn't even breathing at all. His brown eyes, typically sharp and observant, stared blankly into the distance, not focusing on anything, not seeing the world in front of him. He wasn't present in this moment, not really. Instead, he was somewhere deep within himself, far away from the physical discomfort, far away from the rain, far away from the emptiness of the night.

His mind was a chaotic jumble of thoughts—about his life, his choices, his regrets. The same endless questions circled around him like vultures: *Why am I here? What am I doing with my life? How did I end up in this place, in this state?* Rahul had never wanted to be an engineer. The very thought of coding, of dealing with circuits and algorithms, filled him with a sense of dread and disinterest. His true passions, the things that made his heart race, were history and the arts. Ancient civilizations, forgotten cultures, the mysteries of the past—these were the things that stirred his soul. But life hadn't given him the luxury of pursuing what he

loved. He had to be practical. His father had insisted that engineering was the best path, the most secure. And Rahul had listened, not because he believed it, but because he didn't have the heart to disappoint the man who had sacrificed so much for him.

And so here he was, in his final year of computer engineering at Raichand College, a scholarship student, living a life that didn't feel like his own. Every day was a battle, not with the coursework or the professors, but with himself. A battle to get out of bed, to attend classes, to keep going, even though all he wanted was to escape, to disappear into the pages of the history books he loved so much. The future stretched out before him like a dark tunnel, and he couldn't see the end. All he knew was that it wasn't a future he had chosen.

Rahul sighed, the sound almost lost in the constant patter of the rain. He could feel the heaviness in his chest, the weight of his unspoken frustrations, the things he could never say to anyone—not even to his father, who called him regularly, always asking about his studies, always concerned, always hopeful. *How could I tell him the truth?* Rahul thought. *How could I tell him that I'm drowning in this life he wanted for me?* He couldn't. So he didn't. He kept everything locked away, deep inside, and let the rain wash over him, hiding the tears he refused to cry.

The night around him grew darker, the streetlights flickering as the wind began to pick up. What had started as a gentle rain was now growing into something fiercer, more powerful. The wind

howled through the empty streets, sending leaves, trash, and stray pieces of paper tumbling across the road. The peaceful, quiet night was turning into a storm.

It was then that Rahul noticed something—a flash of white, twisting and turning in the wind, caught in the violent currents of the storm. A scarf, bright and vibrant against the dark backdrop of the night, danced through the air like a kite, unattached to anything. Rahul's eyes followed it, almost absentmindedly, as it floated further down the road. And then, out of nowhere, a voice broke through the sound of the wind and the rain.

"Stop! Someone, help! My scarf!"

The voice was high-pitched, filled with urgency and panic. Rahul's head turned slowly toward the sound, and through the sheets of rain, he saw her. A girl, dressed in white, was running after the scarf, her movements clumsy yet determined. Her wet dress clung to her body, and her dark hair whipped around her face as she tried to catch up with the scarf. But the wind was relentless, teasing her, pulling the scarf just out of her reach every time she got close.

Rahul watched her, feeling strangely detached from the whole scene, as if he were watching a movie unfold in slow motion. She slipped, her foot catching on the slick pavement, and fell to her knees with a soft thud. Rahul didn't move, didn't react. He simply watched, the rain still falling heavily on him, as she tried to get up.

The girl stumbled, falling again, her frustration evident even from a distance.

And yet, in the midst of it all, something shifted in Rahul. A smile—a rare, genuine smile—spread across his face, slow and almost hesitant at first, as if he wasn't sure how to feel it anymore. But it was real, and for a moment, the heaviness in his chest lifted. He watched as the girl finally managed to get up, her movements slow and awkward, but determined. Her persistence, her small struggle against the wind, the rain, and her own clumsiness—it all amused him in a way that he hadn't expected. It was like witnessing something pure, something real, amidst the chaos of his own life.

For a brief moment, as she stood there in the rain, a car passed by, its headlights casting a brilliant glow across the street. The light illuminated the girl, and for that fleeting second, she looked almost divine, her wet hair and soaked dress giving her an ethereal, otherworldly appearance. She flipped her hair over her shoulder, the movement graceful despite the rain, and Rahul felt his breath catch in his throat. It was as if the world had paused, holding its breath, just for this moment.

But as quickly as it had come, the moment passed. The car sped away, its headlights blinding Rahul for a second. When he blinked and opened his eyes again, she was gone. The road was empty once more, save for the rain and the storm.

And yet, something had changed. Rahul's smile lingered, soft and genuine, the first one he had worn all day. The scarf—the object of all the chaos—was still fluttering through the air, but this time, it drifted towards him, carried by the wind. Without thinking, Rahul reached out and caught it. The fabric was soft, damp from the rain, and it carried with it the faint warmth of the girl who had chased it so desperately.

He looked around, half-expecting her to reappear and claim it, but there was no one. The street was as empty as it had been moments before. Rahul stood slowly, wrapping the scarf around his hand, feeling its softness against his skin. He didn't know why he kept it. Maybe it was because it reminded him of that fleeting moment of lightness, that rare smile that had crossed his face. Or maybe it was because, for the first time in a long while, he had felt something—something real, something human.

With the scarf still wrapped around his hand, Rahul turned and began walking down the empty street. The rain continued to fall, the wind still howling, but for once, he didn't mind. His mind, usually a battleground of conflicting thoughts, was quiet. The burdens of the day, the pressures of life, the unspoken frustrations—they all seemed distant now. He wasn't thinking about the future, or his father, or his studies. He was simply walking, with a white scarf wrapped around his hand, and a small, quiet smile still lingering on his lips.

And as Rahul disappeared into the night, leaving behind the storm, the rain, and the empty streets of Pune, he felt lighter than he had in a long time.

Chapter 3

Lost and Found in the Rain

Rahul woke up early, the room still dark with only a faint glow of dawn creeping through the curtains. The familiar sound of his alarm hadn't gone off yet, but his body seemed to instinctively know it was time to rise. His flatmates were still asleep, their soft snores muffled by the closed doors of their respective rooms. Rahul slipped out of bed, careful not to make any noise, and moved towards his trunk at the foot of his bed. He knelt down and opened it, searching for clothes to wear for the day.

As he pulled out a neatly folded shirt, his eyes caught something nestled between his clothes—the scarf. The same scarf he had found in the rain the previous evening. Rahul paused, his hand hovering over it. The memory of the girl running in the storm flashed in his mind. The way she had chased the scarf, the way she had fallen, the way she had looked like a fleeting vision under the headlights of that car—it all came back to him in vivid detail.

For a brief moment, he found himself lost in those thoughts again, wondering who she was, where she had come from, and why something as simple as a scarf could carry such weight in that fleeting moment. His fingers brushed the fabric gently, but before he could dwell on it any longer, his phone buzzed, snapping him out of his reverie.

His alarm had gone off, reminding him that it was time for college. Rahul quickly folded the scarf and tucked it deep into his trunk, hiding it beneath layers of clothes. He didn't want anyone in the flat to notice it—especially not a ladies' scarf. It was a reminder of something personal, something he didn't want to share, not even with himself.

After dressing, he headed out, locking the flat behind him, and began his routine journey to college. The morning was just like any other, with the usual hustle of Pune starting to pick up. The crowded PMT bus was the same as every day—filled with people shuffling to their places of work, students heading to classes, and the city moving at its usual frenetic pace. Rahul, however, sat in silence, as always, observing everything but engaging with nothing.

When he reached Raichand College of Engineering, the campus was still waking up. Today, he was earlier than most of his classmates. He made his way to the classroom, quietly finding his seat at the back. As students trickled in, Rahul pulled out one of his history books from his bag. It wasn't part of the college syllabus, but history had always been his escape—his way of diving

into stories that weren't his own, where the characters were long gone, and the world they lived in existed only on pages.

A few minutes passed, and the classroom started to fill. Among the students who entered was Nitin, a fellow student known for his easy-going nature and endless curiosity. Unlike Rahul, Nitin was the kind of guy who made friends easily, moving through the social fabric of college life with ease. When Nitin saw Rahul sitting in the back, he couldn't help but feel drawn to him. He had noticed Rahul many times before—quiet, always alone, and rarely ever speaking to anyone. It intrigued Nitin, and today, for some reason, he felt the need to approach him.

Nitin moved toward Rahul's desk, choosing to sit in the front but turning his body so he could face Rahul. His eyes sparkled with curiosity as he watched Rahul engrossed in his book, seemingly unaware of the world around him. Nitin's curiosity got the better of him, and he leaned in a little closer.

"Hey, Rahul," Nitin said casually, though there was a hint of excitement in his voice.

Rahul barely acknowledged him, his face still hidden behind the pages of his book. He wasn't in the mood for conversation.

Nitin didn't give up. "What are you reading?" he asked, peeking at the cover of the book.

When Rahul didn't respond, Nitin, with childlike enthusiasm, leaned over and grabbed the edge of the book, gently pulling it down to see what had so captivated Rahul's attention. "History?" he said, surprised. "Is this what you read for fun?"

Rahul sighed, realizing that his attempts to stay invisible weren't working. He pulled the book back from Nitin's grasp and simply said, "Yeah," before raising it again to cover his face, hoping that would be the end of the conversation.

But Nitin, undeterred, pressed on. "You really like history, huh? I never figured you for a history buff. Doesn't really go with the whole engineering thing, does it?"

Before Rahul could respond, the classroom door swung open, and the teacher entered, silencing the chatter of the students. Rahul was relieved, taking the opportunity to stand up and greet the teacher along with the rest of the class. But as he sat down, the teacher's eyes landed squarely on him.

"Ah, Rahul," the teacher said with a teasing smile. "On time today, I see. I guess my words finally got through to you, huh?"

The entire class erupted into light laughter. Rahul, unfazed, ignored the remark and resumed staring at his book, his expression blank. He was used to this kind of attention—he had learned to tune it out long ago.

The rest of the day passed in a blur. During lunch, Rahul found a quiet corner of the food court, as he always did. But today, something was different. Nitin, once again, appeared, choosing the table right next to Rahul's. It was clear that Nitin was trying to break through the wall that Rahul had built around himself. He started with small talk, throwing casual comments about the classes, the food, the weather, anything he could think of. Rahul responded in monosyllables—"yes," "no," "hmm"—never giving Nitin the satisfaction of a full conversation.

It wasn't that Rahul didn't want to talk. He just didn't know how to anymore. Years of keeping to himself had made him forget the art of casual conversation, and Nitin's constant attempts to engage him felt like a foreign invasion into his personal space.

Later that day, as they were leaving the college, Nitin caught up with Rahul again. "Hey, you want a ride? I can drop you at your flat," he offered, his voice friendly and open.

Rahul, however, pretended not to hear. He wasn't interested in favors or friendships. Without a word, he walked away, leaving Nitin standing there, puzzled but not discouraged.

This pattern repeated itself over the course of the next week. Nitin would sit near Rahul in class, follow him to the food court during lunch, and offer him rides back home. And each time, Rahul would brush him off, his responses barely more than a grunt or a nod. But Nitin, persistent as ever, didn't seem to mind.

Despite Rahul's cold demeanor, something about him fascinated Nitin. He sensed that beneath the quiet exterior was a depth that few people bothered to see. Nitin wasn't the type to give up easily, and slowly, day by day, his efforts began to wear down Rahul's defenses.

By the end of the week, a strange but undeniable friendship had formed. It wasn't the kind of friendship filled with laughter and shared secrets. No, it was quieter, more subdued. Rahul didn't suddenly become talkative or open up about his life. But he did start acknowledging Nitin's presence, responding with more than just "hmm" or "yes." And Nitin, for his part, seemed content with that. He understood that Rahul wasn't like everyone else, and he respected that.

Rahul didn't know it yet, but Nitin was going to be the one person in college who would manage to break through his carefully constructed walls. In a place filled with hundreds of students, all living their own lives, slowly, through Nitin's cheerful persistence and Rahul's quiet tolerance, they became friends. Rahul had found the one person who wouldn't let him stay invisible.

A week later, as the weekend approached, Rahul found himself with a pile of clothes that needed washing. He opened the old trunk where he kept his clothes, pulling out items one by one. As he reached the bottom of the pile, his hand brushed against something soft—the scarf. He put it on the edge of the desk.

Finishing his basic chores Rahul lay in his bed, staring at the ceiling, the soft white scarf resting on the edge of his desk like a forgotten relic from a dream. The events of that rainy night felt distant now, yet the memory of the girl and the momentary lightness he had experienced lingered. It was unlike him to dwell on something so trivial, but somehow, the image of her clumsy chase after the scarf, the way she had stumbled and fallen, and the divine glow that had surrounded her wouldn't leave his mind.

Pune was quieter today, the streets washed clean by the storm, and the air smelled fresh, tinged with the earthy scent of wet soil. Rahul didn't have any classes that morning, but the usual weight of expectations, of deadlines and responsibilities, still pressed on him. His engineering assignments, upcoming exams, and the suffocating pressure to be perfect felt heavier than usual. Yet, as he sat up and stretched, his eyes caught sight of the scarf again, and he found himself smiling softly.

"Who was she?" he wondered. The question wasn't just about her name or where she lived, but about the strange connection he had felt in that fleeting moment. Rahul wasn't one to believe in fate or destiny, but last night had felt... different. It was as if, for the first time, something unexpected had entered his life, breaking the monotony that had consumed him for so long.

The scarf was soft, its fabric still faintly carrying the scent of rain and something else—something floral, light, and delicate. Rahul

picked it up, feeling its texture between his fingers, before absentmindedly draping it over the back of his chair. He hadn't realized it yet, but that small, seemingly insignificant item had begun to symbolize something bigger—a shift in his world, a subtle but undeniable change in the rhythm of his life.

Despite the calmness of the morning, Rahul couldn't shake the restlessness that had settled in his chest. His flatmates were still asleep, the apartment eerily quiet, but inside Rahul's mind, a storm was brewing. His thoughts kept returning to that girl—her voice, her laughter carried by the wind, and the way she had slipped and gotten back up, her determination unwavering even in the chaos of the storm.

Unable to focus on anything else, Rahul decided to step out. The streets outside were still wet, puddles reflecting the soft glow of the sun as it tried to break through the lingering clouds. He found himself walking aimlessly, his feet carrying him without purpose, but his mind kept turning over questions he couldn't answer. Why did she leave such an impression on me? What was it about her that I can't forget?

As he wandered through the narrow streets of Pune, Rahul's mind continued to drift. The city was coming to life around him, the shops opening, the street vendors setting up their carts, and the usual buzz of activity slowly returning. Yet, it all felt distant to him, as though he were walking through a dream, detached from the world. His thoughts were far away, back in the rain-soaked streets

of the night before, where he had felt something—something he hadn't felt in a long time.

After walking for what felt like hours, Rahul found himself standing in front of a familiar café. It was a small, cozy place, tucked away on a quiet street corner, one of the few places in the city where he felt comfortable. He had been coming here for years, finding solace in its quiet atmosphere and the fact that it was always just out of the way enough to avoid the usual crowds.

He stepped inside, the bell above the door jingling softly as he entered. The warmth of the café wrapped around him like a blanket, and the smell of freshly brewed coffee filled the air. Rahul made his way to his usual table by the window and sat down, the scarf still tucked in his pocket. As he waited for his coffee, he stared out of the window, watching the world go by, but his mind was somewhere else entirely.

The memory of the girl, the rain, and that strange moment of connection wouldn't leave him. He had no idea who she was, no way of finding her, yet the thought of her lingered in his mind, like a song stuck on repeat. Rahul wasn't the type to get caught up in fleeting encounters, but this time felt different. There was something about her—something that had shaken him out of his usual apathy, even if just for a moment.

His coffee arrived, and he took a sip, letting the warmth spread through him, but even the familiar taste couldn't pull him back to

the present. His mind was too preoccupied with the what-ifs and the questions that had no answers.

"Why do I even care?" he thought to himself, frustrated by his own preoccupation. "It's not like I'll ever see her again. It was just one night, one random encounter. Nothing more."

But even as he tried to convince himself of that, Rahul knew it wasn't true. There was something about that night, something about her, that had left an imprint on him—a mark he couldn't erase, no matter how hard he tried.

As the day wore on, Rahul found himself back at his flat, lying on his bed, staring at the ceiling once more. The scarf was still draped over the chair, a constant reminder of the girl he couldn't forget. He had tried to distract himself, tried to focus on other things, but his mind kept drifting back to her, back to that moment in the rain.

And then, almost without realizing it, Rahul made a decision. He wasn't sure why, but he knew he had to find her. It wasn't just about returning the scarf; it was about something deeper, something he couldn't explain. There was a pull, a magnetic force drawing him towards her, and he knew he couldn't ignore it.

The next few days passed in a blur. Rahul went through the motions of his daily life—attending classes, studying for exams, hanging out with his flatmates—but all the while, his mind was elsewhere. He found himself scanning every crowd, every street,

looking for a glimpse of the girl in the white dress, hoping for another chance encounter. But she was nowhere to be found.

Each day that passed, the scarf became more than just a piece of fabric. It was a symbol—a reminder of that brief moment of lightness, of the possibility that something, or someone, could pull him out of the suffocating weight of his own thoughts. He kept it with him, tucked in his bag or pocket, always within reach, as if it were a talisman, a connection to the girl he couldn't forget.

Weeks went by, and still, Rahul couldn't shake the feeling that he was meant to find her. The logical part of his brain told him to let it go, that it was just a random encounter, nothing more. But the deeper, more instinctual part of him knew that there was something more to it—something he needed to understand.

And so, one rainy evening, much like the night he had first seen her, Rahul found himself walking through the streets of Pune once again, the white scarf tucked into the pocket of his jacket. The rain fell steadily, soft but persistent, and the city seemed to glow in the twilight, its lights reflected in the wet pavement.

As he walked, his eyes scanned the crowd, searching for any sign of her. He didn't know where he was going or what he would say if he found her, but he knew he had to keep looking. There was a sense of anticipation in the air, a feeling that something was about to happen, though Rahul couldn't quite put his finger on what.

And then, as if by some twist of fate, he saw her.

She was standing at a street corner, her back to him, her long, dark hair cascading down her back, wet from the rain. She wasn't wearing the white dress this time, but he recognized her immediately. His heart skipped a beat, and for a moment, he stood frozen, unsure of what to do.

But then, before he could think, before he could second-guess himself, Rahul began to walk towards her.

As he approached, his mind raced with a thousand thoughts, but the one that stood out the most was the inexplicable feeling that this moment, this encounter, was important—more important than anything he had ever experienced before.

And as he reached her, standing in the rain with the white scarf in his hand, Rahul knew that whatever happened next would change everything.

Chapter 4

Rain or Mist

The rain had softened into a light drizzle by the time Rahul reached her, the scarf still balled in his hand, damp from his grip. The girl stood at the corner, unaware of his approach, her back still turned to him as she looked down the road. Rahul's breath hitched in his throat, his heart beating faster than he could remember. He had imagined this moment for weeks—what he would say, how she would react—but now that he was here, words seemed impossible to form. His mind went blank, every well-thought-out line dissolving under the weight of the moment.

She turned her head slightly as if sensing someone behind her. Her profile was just as he remembered: soft, delicate features framed by wet strands of dark hair, her eyes downcast, lost in her own thoughts. For a second, Rahul thought about turning away. The strangeness of the situation overwhelmed him. What if she didn't remember him? What if she thought he was a creep for following her?

But then, almost instinctively, he stepped forward and softly said, "Hey..."

The word was simple, but it seemed to echo through the air, amplified by the quiet of the rainy evening. The girl turned fully now, her eyes widening slightly when she saw him. There was a flicker of recognition in her expression—brief but unmistakable.

She blinked, her gaze dropping to the scarf in his hand. The realization hit her, and a soft smile tugged at the corners of her lips.

"I think... this belongs to you," Rahul said, holding out the scarf. His voice was calm, but inside, he was a maelstrom of nerves. He hadn't expected this—hadn't expected her to smile.

The girl laughed softly, the sound like music cutting through the drizzle. It wasn't a loud laugh, but it was genuine, and for a second, it was as though the rain and the cold didn't exist. Her laughter warmed him from the inside, something about it felt familiar, comforting in a way he couldn't quite explain.

"Thank you," she said, reaching out to take the scarf. Her fingers brushed against his for the briefest moment, sending a jolt of warmth through him. She glanced at the scarf, then back at him. "I thought I'd lost it forever... that storm was crazy."

Rahul nodded, smiling slightly, though his heart was pounding. He realized that this moment wasn't anything like what he had imagined, but somehow, it was better. It was real, not some grand, cinematic meeting but a quiet, almost tender exchange. "Yeah... it

was," he replied, his voice softer now. "I found it after... after you left."

She blinked again, clearly trying to place him in her memory. "You were there that night... by the tree, right?"

Rahul nodded, feeling a strange sense of relief wash over him. She remembers me, he thought, his heart lightening.

The girl's smile widened, and for the first time, Rahul saw her fully. On that rainy night, he hadn't been able to see her face clearly—everything had been a blur in the storm. But now, as he looked at her, he realized that the hazy image from before had transformed into something more beautiful than he had imagined. The blurred face was now clear, and the reality of her presence made his chest tighten.

"I must have looked ridiculous," she said, laughing again as she wrapped the scarf loosely around her neck. "Running after a scarf in the middle of a thunderstorm. You must've thought I was crazy."

Rahul shook his head. "Not at all," he said, surprising himself with the honesty of his words. "I thought you were... brave, actually. I don't think I would've gone after something like that in a storm."

Her eyes sparkled with amusement, and she tilted her head, studying him for a moment. "Brave? That's an interesting way of putting it," she said. "I think 'reckless' might be more accurate."

Rahul shrugged, his lips curving into a faint smile. "Maybe a little of both."

For a moment, they just stood there, the rain falling softly around them, the world seeming to fade into the background. Rahul hadn't expected this—hadn't expected to feel so comfortable with her, a complete stranger. But then again, she didn't feel like a stranger. Not really. It was as if they had shared something in that storm, something unspoken but real.

"What's your name?" she asked suddenly, her voice gentle.

"Rahul," he replied.

She smiled softly, and for a while, neither of them spoke. They stood there, soaking in the quiet as the rain slowed to a gentle mist, the streetlights casting a soft glow over the wet pavement. It was a peaceful moment, a quiet respite from the chaos of the world around them.

After a while, she broke the silence. "Do you... want to get a coffee or something?" she asked, her tone casual but hopeful.

Rahul hesitated for a moment, surprised by the invitation. He wasn't used to this—wasn't used to people inviting him in. But something about her made him want to say yes. She wasn't like anyone he had ever met before. There was a warmth to her, a lightness that seemed to draw him in, even though he barely knew her.

"Sure," he said finally, a small smile playing on his lips. "I'd like that."

Her smile brightened at his response, and she nodded toward a small café down the street. "Come on, I know a place."

As they began walking together, side by side, the distance between them seemed to shrink. At one point, their hands brushed lightly. It was an innocent touch, but it sent a jolt of electricity through Rahul. Neither of them pulled away. Instead, their fingers hesitantly intertwined, as if it were the most natural thing in the world. For a moment, they walked like that, hands held, the connection between them feeling strangely perfect, as though the rain, the scarf, and the storm had all led to this moment.

But just as Rahul felt the warmth of her hand settle his racing heart, a sudden disorientation washed over him. The world around him seemed to blur, the soft drizzle and the glow of the streetlights fading into nothingness. His eyelids fluttered, and when he opened them again, he found himself lying in his bed, alone. The faint sound of rain still echoed outside, but the girl was gone. It had all been a dream.

Rahul sat up slowly, the lingering feeling of her touch fading into the quiet darkness of his room. He let out a soft breath, half-disappointed, half-amused. It had felt so real.

The dream had left Rahul with a hollow ache, and as he sat up in the dim stillness of his room, he realized something within him had shifted.

Realizing how absurd it was to keep holding on to the scarf. He didn't even know the girl, and yet here he was, treating the scarf like it meant something.

With a heavy heart, he took the scarf—the one that had once felt like a connection to something greater—and buried it deep in his closet, shoving it into the darkest corner where it wouldn't accidentally resurface. He wanted it hidden, forgotten, and with it, the girl who had become little more than a dream.

He didn't need distractions like this—he had enough to deal with. Engineering exams were coming up, and the weight of expectations from his professors and his family were already overwhelming.

The hope he'd clung to, the possibility of seeing her again, had dissolved into the quiet realization that it was all just fantasy. He decided then and there not to think about her anymore, to stop chasing ghosts in the rain.

The decision Rahul made that night weighed on him heavily, but it felt necessary. He had spent too long indulging in dreams and fleeting emotions, and it was time to let go. Engineering exams

were approaching, and the pressures from all sides—family, professors, and the future—were suffocating. He couldn't afford to be distracted anymore. Life, as he reminded himself, wasn't a romantic story. The scarf was hidden, the girl was forgotten, and Rahul was ready to move on.

Or so he thought.

The following weeks slipped by in a blur. Rahul threw himself into his studies, staying late at the library, taking notes, and preparing for the grueling exams ahead. He kept his interactions with Nitin and others to a minimum, though Nitin's cheerful persistence made it hard to avoid him entirely. Yet despite Rahul's efforts to stay focused, something inside him felt off-balance. The rain-soaked memory of the girl still clung to the edges of his mind, no matter how hard he tried to bury it.

One afternoon, as he sat in the library with a stack of textbooks, Rahul noticed the faint patter of rain on the window beside him. The world outside was grey, the sky heavy with clouds. His pen hovered over the notes he had been writing, but his mind was far from the equations on the page. His thoughts drifted, once again, to that rainy night, to the girl and the scarf, and the brief moment of connection they had shared—even if only in his dreams.

"Are you daydreaming again?" Nitin's voice snapped Rahul back to the present. He looked up, startled, to see Nitin grinning at him from across the table.

"I'm not," Rahul muttered, quickly closing his notebook as if to shield himself from the accusation.

"Right," Nitin said, his tone teasing but light. "You've been staring out the window for the past ten minutes."

Rahul shrugged, not willing to admit that Nitin was right. He couldn't explain the strange emptiness that had settled over him, the sense of something unfinished that gnawed at him in the quiet moments. He wasn't supposed to be thinking about her. He wasn't supposed to be chasing ghosts in the rain, as he had told himself. But it seemed like no matter how hard he tried, she was still there, somewhere in the back of his mind.

"Come on, Rahul," Nitin said, changing the subject. "Let's grab some food. You've been cooped up in here all day."

Rahul hesitated for a moment, but eventually agreed. He packed up his books, slinging his bag over his shoulder as they headed out of the library together. The rain had stopped by the time they stepped outside, leaving the streets wet and the air cool. Nitin chattered on about an upcoming event at college, but Rahul's thoughts were elsewhere, his mind drifting back to the girl once more.

As they walked past the row of shops and cafes that lined the street, something caught Rahul's eye. His heart skipped a beat, and he stopped in his tracks. There, hanging in the window of a small boutique, was a scarf. Not just any scarf—it was the same

delicate white fabric, the same one from that night. It was impossible, and yet, it was there.

Rahul's feet moved on their own as he stepped toward the window, his breath catching in his throat. For a moment, the world around him seemed to fall away, and all he could see was the scarf. He reached out, his hand hovering just above the glass, as if he could reach through and grasp it. But before he could make sense of what he was seeing, Nitin's voice cut through his trance.

"Rahul? You okay, man?"

Rahul blinked, the spell broken. He turned to Nitin, trying to shake off the strange feeling that had come over him. "Yeah, I'm fine. Just... thought I saw something."

Nitin glanced at the window, then back at Rahul, his expression puzzled but concerned. "You sure? You've been acting weird lately."

"I'm fine," Rahul repeated, more to convince himself than Nitin. He forced himself to step away from the window, from the scarf, and continued walking. But the image of it lingered in his mind, stirring up emotions he had been trying so hard to bury.

That night, back in his room, Rahul couldn't sleep. He lay awake, staring at the ceiling, the sound of rain once again tapping against his window. The scarf in the boutique window had been just a coincidence, he told himself. It wasn't her scarf, it couldn't be. And yet, he couldn't shake the feeling that it meant something.

Eventually, he gave in. Throwing off his covers, he got out of bed and opened the closet where he had hidden the scarf. His hand trembled slightly as he pulled it out, the soft fabric sliding through his fingers like water. He sat down on the edge of his bed, holding the scarf in his lap, and for the first time in weeks, he allowed himself to feel.

The girl had been real. The night had been real. And somewhere, deep inside, Rahul knew that his connection to her, no matter how brief, had changed him in ways he wasn't ready to admit. He hadn't been able to let go, because he didn't want to. He wasn't chasing ghosts in the rain—he was chasing something more.

With a heavy sigh, Rahul folded the scarf carefully and placed it back in the trunk, but this time, he didn't bury it. Instead, he left it on top, where he could see it. Maybe he wasn't ready to give up on the girl after all.

And as he lay back down, the soft sound of rain still falling outside, Rahul realized that maybe some things were worth holding onto. Even if they were just a dream.

Chapter 5

A New Distraction

Days passed with the usual monotony of college life. Rahul and Nitin were in class, their usual routine punctuated by the drone of the professor's voice. Rahul's face remained expressionless, his attention drifting between the lecture and the ever-present hum of his thoughts. The classroom was filled with the quiet rustling of pages and occasional scribbles on notebooks.

Just as the lecture concluded, an announcement crackled over the loudspeaker, startling some students out of their daze. "Attention, students. According to the curriculum for this semester, each student must participate in an engaging activity, group, or event. This is a graded requirement. Failure to participate will result in a backlog. The activity can be done across various departments; you may join groups from any department across science, arts, commerce, pharmacy, or any other faculty within the campus."

The announcement hung in the air like a heavy fog, and Rahul's heart sank. The thought of having to interact with people, engage in group activities, and be part of something he wasn't interested in was daunting. His usual calm demeanor cracked just a bit as he

exchanged a glance with Nitin, who was already frowning in response.

As the students shuffled out of the classroom, Rahul and Nitin made their way to the food court. Nitin, always the optimist, began discussing what he wanted for lunch. "I'm thinking of trying zanzanit misal pav today. What do you think?"

Rahul was lost in his own world, his mind swirling with the implications of the announcement. "Hmm, poha sounds good," he replied absentmindedly.

Nitin raised an eyebrow. "Poha? I said misal pav!"

"Oh, right. Misal pav it is," Rahul said, still not fully engaged in the conversation.

Nitin noticed Rahul's distraction and, with a knowing smile, said, "I know you're not thrilled about this whole activity thing. I've got a plan. I asked a friend for a list of the clubs in our college. We can join the least popular one—minimal interaction, just how you like it."

Rahul's eyes lit up with a glimmer of hope. "Really? That sounds perfect. Forward it to me quietly, will you?"

Nitin grinned, seeing Rahul's relief. "Of course! I've got you covered." They continued their conversation, with Nitin detailing the list he'd received. Among the options was the Psychology

Club—referred to on the list as “PsyClub”—which had been empty for the past two semesters.

“Rahul, check this out!” Nitin exclaimed. “I’ve got the list of clubs. Look, there’s a psychology club that’s had zero members for the past two semesters.”

Rahul glanced at the list with disinterest. “And?”

“Looks like this might be our best bet. Zero members,” Nitin said, showing the list to Rahul. “Do you have any interest in psychology?”

Rahul shook his head. “Nope. But if it’s empty, fine by me. I’ll join.” Nitin, always the social one, said, “Good to know. I’ll join too if you’re up for it. If not, I’ll check out other groups. I’m sure we can find something that suits our preferences.”

They agreed to sign up for the club after classes. Rahul felt a small sigh of relief knowing he would avoid crowded activities.

Later, as the college hours ended, the campus was abuzz with students gathering around, forming groups, and trying to recruit others for various clubs. Rahul, eager to avoid the chaos, slipped away unnoticed. He headed toward the Arts Building, where the PsyClub was located.

The Arts Building was a stark contrast to the bustling engineering corridors. It was quieter, with the occasional echo of footsteps and distant conversations. Rahul navigated through the crowd,

slipping between groups of students, until he reached the back corridors of the building.

The hallway was dimly lit, with soft lighting that barely illuminated the faded posters on the walls. The corridor was lined with doors leading to various departments, and at the very end was the Psychology Department. As Rahul approached the door of the PsyClub, he was relieved to find the hallway empty—a welcome change from the crowded areas he'd just navigated.

Taking a deep breath, Rahul opened the door to the club room. The room was sparsely furnished, with a few old chairs and a large table in the center. The windows were partially covered with dusty blinds, letting in just enough light to cast a soft glow across the room.

Standing by the window was a girl, her back to Rahul. She was gazing outside, the light casting a gentle halo around her silhouette. Her long, thick hair flowed down her back, catching the light and giving it a rich, lustrous sheen. Her posture was relaxed, but there was an air of contemplation about her. The soft light filtering through the window highlighted her delicate features—her profile was elegant, with a beautiful face and a bit of chubby cheeks.

For a moment, Rahul's breath caught in his throat. She was strikingly beautiful, and there was something familiar about her. Her eyelashes fluttered as she blinked, casting shadows on her

cheeks. The scene seemed almost ethereal—like a vision from his dreams.

His heart skipped a beat as he recalled the girl he'd seen on that rainy night. The resemblance was uncanny, but Rahul quickly dismissed the thought. "It's just my imagination," he muttered to himself. "Every beautiful girl seems like her now." "She can't be the same girl."

Shaking his head, he tried to rid himself of the thought and focused on the practical matters at hand. He needed to register and get out of the room before anyone else showed up.

He stepped inside, and the girl turned around, revealing a warm, friendly smile. She was a fair girl, about 5'4", with striking eyes and a bit of chubby cheeks that gave her a youthful charm. As she saw Rahul, she took a step towards him and asked, "You're here for the psychology club too?"

Rahul, feeling slightly uncomfortable under her gaze, nodded quietly. Naina's presence was calming, but he was still unsure about his decision. "Yes," he said, "I'm here to join."

The Girl, noticing Rahul's hesitance, said, "I'm here for the same reason. I'm just waiting for the club in-charge to arrive. We can register together."

Rahul, feeling his frustration rise, thought about leaving. It seemed that every time he tried to avoid people, he ended up right in the middle of it.

Just as he was about to turn away, the door opened again, and Nitin entered with a broad smile. "Rahul, there you are! I was looking for you. I thought you'd be alone here, but I see you're already meeting people."

Nitin glanced at the girl and greeted her, introducing himself and making small talk.

The Girl smiled and introduced herself more formally. "Hi, I'm Naina. I'm a psychology student here. This club was started by my sister, Sunaina, a few years ago. She's now graduated, and I've taken over. For the past two semesters, the club has had no members, so I'm here to keep it alive. It would be a shame to see it closed down."

He then turned to Rahul. "I'm already committed to another group, so I won't be able to join this one. But if you need any help, just let me know."

Naina looked a bit disappointed but nodded.

Nitin and Naina continued to chat, and Rahul remained mostly silent. Naina turned to him and asked, "So, Rahul, why did you decide to join the Psychology Club? Most students from the engineering department don't usually show interest in arts."

Without thinking, Rahul blurted out, "I thought it would be quiet here, so I joined." He glanced at Nitin, who looked like he was about to burst with laughter.

Naina seemed taken aback but remained polite. "Oh, well, I'm glad to have you here. Even if you're not interested in psychology, your presence will help us keep the club alive.

"Alright. I'll just finish up the paperwork and confirm our membership. Thank you for coming, Rahul."

Nitin left the room, and Rahul was left alone with Naina. As they chatted, Rahul found himself growing more comfortable. Naina's enthusiasm for the club and her genuine personality began to win him over.

Naina excitedly shared her plans for the club's activities. "I want to keep this club alive because it was started by my elder sister, Sunaina. She was really passionate about it, and I don't want it to disappear. We'll have discussions, workshops, and guest lectures. It should be interesting!"

Rahul, though initially resistant, found himself softening. "Okay, I guess I'll give it a try."

Naina's face lit up with joy. "Thank you so much! It means a lot. I'll make sure we have a great time here."

"I'll go inform the club associate teacher about our membership and get everything sorted."

As Naina left, Nitin re-entered the room and whispered to Rahul with a grin. "I saw you smiling! Did you like her?"

Rahul, trying to maintain his usual indifferent facade, replied, "No, she's just... childish. That's why I was laughing. I don't like her."

Nitin chuckled, "Sure, keep telling yourself that. But there's definitely something about her. Anyway, I'm sure you'll find it interesting. Who knows, you might even learn something new."

Rahul didn't respond, instead choosing to inspect the room's dusty furniture and cobwebbed corners. The old bookshelves were filled with psychology textbooks and old files, many of which looked like they hadn't been touched in years. It was a stark contrast to the bustling world of engineering he was used to.

Nitin got a call and he moved out saying "hello! Helloooo, hellooowwww"!

As Naina returned with the necessary paperwork, the atmosphere in the room shifted. Her vibrant presence seemed to breathe new life into the space. She handed the form to Rahul, ensuring he filled out the details.

"So, here's the deal," Naina said, organizing the paperwork. "We're going to start with a few basic activities—discussions on

psychological theories, guest lectures, and maybe even some workshops if we can get enough participants. I'm planning to invite some professors and professionals from the field, so it should be interesting."

Rahul glanced at the forms, his mind still wrestling with his discomfort about this new arrangement. He filled out the details, but his thoughts kept drifting back to the girl from the rainy night. The image of her, ethereal and almost magical in the storm's glow, lingered in his mind.

Naina, sensing Rahul's distraction, paused. "Is everything alright, Rahul? You seem a bit off."

Startled, Rahul looked up. "Oh, yeah. Just... thinking about something."

Naina offered a sympathetic smile. "If you ever need someone to talk to or if you have any concerns about the club, feel free to reach out. I'm here to make this experience as smooth as possible for everyone."

Rahul nodded, appreciating her kindness but still feeling uncertain. The idea of opening up to someone about his personal struggles felt uncomfortable. He preferred to keep his thoughts and emotions to himself.

With the registration process complete, Naina gave Rahul a brief tour of the club's meager resources. They talked about the

upcoming events and the goals Naina hoped to achieve with the club. Rahul listened attentively but remained reserved, his mind drifting back to the unexpected joy he'd felt when he first saw Naina's smile.

Ttyl , GTG!, said Rahul with his emotionless face

'Looking forward for a great team Rahul 🤔'!

As Rahul left the room, he couldn't help but notice Naina's happiness. She seemed genuinely excited about keeping the club alive, and her enthusiasm was contagious. Rahul's earlier discomfort began to fade, replaced by a tentative optimism.

As he walked back to his dorm, Nitin caught up with him.
See? That wasn't so bad. You might actually enjoy it once you get used to it."

Rahul shrugged, trying to appear nonchalant. "Yeah, maybe. We'll see."

Nitin smirked. "Sure, sure. Whatever you say."

Rahul and Nitin parted ways Nitin went to get his bike, and Rahul couldn't shake the feeling that the psychology club, with all its quirks and challenges, might just become a more significant part of his college life than he'd anticipated.

Later, as Naina walked to the bus stand, she glanced back at Rahul. "Hey, I've successfully registered us for the club. See you around!"

Rahul nodded, feeling a mix of relief and curiosity. "Okay. See you." Naina's cheerful wave and smile were infectious, even as Rahul tried to maintain his composure. As he walked away, Nitin's voice called out from behind, "You know, if I were you, I'd have walked with her. She seemed really nice."

Rahul just shook his head with a small smile. "Shut up, Nitin. Let's go."

Over the next few days, Rahul found himself reluctantly attending the club meetings. He wasn't entirely comfortable with the discussions, but he observed the interactions with curiosity. Naina's enthusiasm and genuine interest in psychology made the sessions more engaging. Her passion was evident in the way she spoke, her eyes sparkling with excitement when discussing various topics.

One particular evening, after a lengthy discussion on cognitive behavioral therapy, Rahul lingered behind to help Naina clean up. It was just the two of them in the room, and the quiet conversation that followed was more relaxed.

"Thank you for helping with the cleanup," Naina said, wiping down the tables. "I appreciate it. It's nice to have someone who's willing to contribute."

Rahul, surprised by her gratitude, replied, "It's no problem. I'm just doing what I can."

Naina looked at him with a thoughtful expression. "You know, I've noticed you seem a bit out of place. If you want, we can talk about it. Sometimes it helps to share what's on your mind."

Rahul hesitated. He wasn't used to opening up to others, but Naina's sincerity made it tempting. "I don't know. I'm just... trying to figure things out."

Naina nodded understandingly. "I get it. We all have our struggles. But remember, you're not alone. Sometimes it helps to share your burdens, even if it's just with a friend."

The conversation shifted to lighter topics as they continued tidying up. Rahul found himself enjoying the camaraderie, though he still struggled with his reservations.

As weeks passed, Rahul became more accustomed to the club's activities. He started to look forward to the meetings, finding solace in the routine. Naina's presence was a constant source of comfort. Her genuine interest in him and the club helped Rahul gradually open up.

One evening, after a particularly engaging discussion, Naina invited Rahul to join her for a coffee. "You've been really dedicated

lately. How about we grab a coffee and chat outside? It's a nice evening."

Rahul, feeling a bit adventurous, agreed. They walked to a nearby café, the cool evening breeze contrasting with the warmth of the café's interior. The conversation flowed easily, and Rahul found himself sharing more than he had intended.

Naina listened attentively, her empathy evident in her responses. "You know, I think you're doing great. Sometimes it's hard to see, but the effort you're putting into the club and your studies is impressive."

Rahul, feeling a sense of relief, smiled. "Thanks. I've been trying to make the best of things."

Their time together felt refreshing, and Rahul began to appreciate Naina's company. The barriers he had built around himself started to dissolve, though he still maintained a guarded demeanor.

As they parted ways that evening, Rahul couldn't help but feel a sense of anticipation. The club, once a source of dread, had become a place of unexpected connection. Naina's presence, once merely a curiosity, had become a significant part of his daily life.

He walked back to his dorm with a renewed sense of purpose, his thoughts now filled with possibilities. The encounter with Naina had opened a new chapter in his life—one that was filled with potential and hope.

Chapter 6

The Fear of Unworthiness

Rahul and Naina's friendship had quickly become a part of Rahul's daily life, almost like a ritual that he didn't question or analyze too much. Every day, they worked together on tasks for the club, and even when there was no specific work, they found themselves sitting in the club room. It had become a silent agreement between them—a comfort in each other's company, even in silence.

It wasn't that they always talked. In fact, Rahul often found himself simply watching her as she hummed absentmindedly while organizing papers, or while she tapped her foot to some silent beat only she could hear. He liked these moments, where no words were needed, where just being around her felt... natural.

But Naina, ever the energetic force, rarely let Rahul be comfortable for too long. Whenever she felt the least bit bored, she would look at him with those bright eyes of hers, lean over the

table, and say, "Let's go grab coffee!" Before he could even refuse, she'd already be dragging him out of the room.

Rahul didn't mind, though. In fact, he liked these little excursions. They would go to the crowded college cafeteria, find a small corner for themselves, and while Naina busied herself with her coffee and endless stories about her day, Rahul would simply watch. He didn't say much, just listened to the rhythm of her voice. Naina had become a constant in his life—a presence he looked forward to, without realizing how much he had started depending on it.

Naina was not just any girl in college. She was one of the most well-known and admired students across all departments. She was a fantastic dancer, fluent in English, a natural public speaker, and the first choice as the anchor for nearly every college event. Her reputation was undeniable. She had a magnetic presence; people couldn't help but be drawn to her. Her beauty was just the cherry on top—wherever she went, she naturally became the center of attention.

And so, when people started noticing Rahul and Naina spending more and more time together, it wasn't long before the whispers began. It wasn't that Rahul was unattractive—he had his own quiet charm—but compared to Naina's vibrant personality, he seemed almost... out of place. His goofy, introverted nature didn't quite match the glamorous, outgoing image Naina portrayed.

Soon, the campus began buzzing with questions: "Why is she hanging out with him?" "Isn't she way out of his league?" "Why would she, of all people, spend time with someone like Rahul?" The whispers followed them everywhere they went, though Naina seemed blissfully unaware. She didn't care what people thought. But Rahul... Rahul couldn't ignore it.

One afternoon, after they had finished another task in the club, they found themselves back in the cafeteria. Naina was exhausted, her usual lively energy slightly dulled as she sipped her coffee, eyes half-closed in contentment. Rahul, as usual, sat across from her, his eyes resting on her face. She looked peaceful, even in her weariness, and something about that made him smile. She was so comfortable around him, so unguarded—it was a side of her that not everyone got to see.

But behind them, at a table just a few feet away, sat a group of girls, their voices carrying over the usual cafeteria noise. Rahul wasn't paying attention at first, but then, he heard it.

"Look at her," one of the girls muttered, loud enough for him to hear. "Why is she always with that goofy Rahul? I mean, seriously, she could do so much better."

"Yeah," another girl chimed in. "She's like... one of the most popular girls in college. Everyone knows her. She's beautiful, smart, talented. And then there's him. He just sits there, staring at her like a puppy. He's ruining her image."

Rahul froze. The words hit him like a punch to the gut. He tried to focus on Naina, who was completely unaware of the conversation happening behind her. She took another sip of her coffee, her face relaxed, enjoying the small break in their hectic day. But Rahul couldn't unhear the words. They echoed in his head, growing louder with every passing second.

He told himself to brush it off. He had never cared what people thought of him before, so why start now? But this was different. This wasn't just about him—it was about Naina. She was special, and people were beginning to question why she was spending time with him. They were starting to judge her for it.

As Naina finished her coffee and stood up, stretching her arms lazily, Rahul plastered on a smile and said, "I'll see you tomorrow, yeah?" He didn't let on that anything was wrong. She smiled back, waved, and headed off to her next activity. But as Rahul left the cafeteria and walked toward the bus stop, the words from those girls played on a loop in his mind.

"She could do so much better."

"Why him?"

"He's ruining her image."

By the time Rahul reached the bus stop, the thoughts had twisted into something darker. He leaned against the bus shelter, staring at the ground, his mind spinning in circles.

"Maybe they're right," he thought. "What am I even doing? Why is she hanging out with me?"

He had always known Naina was out of his league. She was someone who could light up a room just by walking into it, while he preferred to fade into the background. She was confident, outgoing, effortlessly charming. And he... well, he was Rahul. Quiet, introspective, and awkward. He didn't belong in the same social sphere as her. Maybe people were starting to see that. Maybe they were right to question why someone like her would spend time with someone like him.

"What if she realizes it too?" The thought crept into his mind like a shadow, cold and unwelcome. "What if one day, she realizes she could be with someone better? Someone more suited to her world?"

The bus arrived, but Rahul didn't move. He stood there, lost in his thoughts, letting the bus come and go without even noticing. He didn't want to think about it, but he couldn't stop. The more he tried to push the thoughts away, the stronger they came back.

"She's my friend now," he tried to reassure himself. "We're just friends. That's all. It's fine."

But even as he thought it, the doubts gnawed at him. What if being around him was bad for her? What if people started looking at her differently because of him? She had worked hard to build her

reputation, to become someone people admired. And here he was, potentially ruining it just by being in her life.

Rahul shook his head, trying to clear the negative thoughts, but they clung to him like a dark cloud. He didn't want to think about it anymore. He didn't want to let those girls' words get to him. But they had. And now, he wasn't sure how to stop overthinking every moment he spent with Naina.

As he stood there, alone at the bus stop, watching the sun dip below the horizon, a sinking feeling settled in his chest. He wasn't sure what it was, but he couldn't shake the fear that, one day, Naina would see what everyone else saw: that he wasn't good enough for her. And when that day came, she might walk away.

And that thought, more than anything, terrified him.

Chapter 7

The Silent Departure

The day had been unusually chaotic for Rahul. His professor had kept him late after class, discussing the intricacies of an assignment that seemed far more important to the professor than it did to him. By the time he was finally freed, the sun had begun to cast long shadows through the windows of the nearly deserted campus. He hurried his way across the grounds toward the arts department, where the club was tucked away in a quiet corner. It was a place that had become his refuge in the bustling, noisy world of Raichand College. There, he could sit with Naina, work on tasks for the club, and enjoy the silence that seemed to stretch between them—comfortable, effortless, and safe.

As Rahul walked through the empty corridors, the click of his shoes echoed off the walls. The arts department always had a different feel from the rest of the college, quieter, more introspective. The stark contrast to the engineering department where he spent most of his time. But today, as he approached the club, he heard voices—faint but unmistakable. He slowed his pace, straining to listen.

It was a group of girls, their laughter floating through the corridor like an invasive whisper. Rahul's brows furrowed as he got closer

to the door of the club. He recognized the voice of one of the girls immediately—Naina. His heart gave a small, involuntary leap, as it often did when he heard her. But something in the tone of the conversation stopped him from walking in.

"...God, Naina, why are you always here? In this dingy club?" one of the girls was saying. Her voice was filled with disdain, like the very idea of the club repulsed her.

"And with *him*," the girl continued, drawing out the word with a mix of disbelief and disgust. "*Rahul?*" I mean, seriously, Naina. What are you doing with him?"

Rahul's heart sank. He took a hesitant step back from the door, his stomach tightening. He recognized the girl now—Tanya, one of the most popular girls in the college. Her sharp tongue was well-known, and Rahul had always made it a point to avoid her. He hadn't expected to hear his name from her lips, though.

The other girl, Meera, jumped in, her tone equally condescending. "Yeah, everyone's talking, you know? It's not good for your image. Rahul's... well, he's weird. He's not like us. He doesn't fit in. You deserve better than hanging out with someone like *that*."

Rahul's breath caught in his throat. He instinctively took another step back, pressing himself against the wall just outside the door. His heart pounded, and his mind raced. He felt a sharp sting in his chest, the words echoing inside his head, bouncing around like sharp-edged stones. His ears burned as he heard them describe

him with such casual cruelty, like he was nothing more than an inconvenient blemish in Naina's otherwise spotless life.

But then, Naina's voice broke through, softer, but steady. "You guys don't understand," she said, and Rahul's heart fluttered with a mix of hope and dread. "Rahul is a good person. He's my friend, and I like spending time with him. It doesn't matter what anyone else says."

There was an awkward silence that followed. Rahul imagined the shocked expressions on Tanya and Meera's faces. They were probably not used to being challenged, especially not by Naina, who was so often the epitome of diplomacy. But Naina, as gentle as she was, had a certain strength to her. Rahul knew that better than most.

Tanya was the first to break the silence, her voice sharp and defensive. "I don't know what he's done to you, Naina, but seriously, you need to think about this. You're Naina Sharma, for God's sake! The face of every event in college. You don't want to be known as the girl who's hanging out with some awkward, goofy guy who barely talks to anyone."

Rahul felt his face flush with a mix of embarrassment and shame. It was true. He wasn't like them. He wasn't outgoing or charming. He didn't know how to hold conversations that mattered in the grand scheme of college politics. He didn't belong in their world, and now, he was dragging Naina down. The realization hit him with

the force of a tidal wave, washing over him, drowning him in a sea of self-doubt.

"I don't care," Naina's voice interrupted his spiral. "You don't know him like I do. Rahul is... special. He's different, sure, but that's not a bad thing. I don't need to justify my friendship with him to anyone."

Rahul's chest tightened. The sting of the girls' words hadn't subsided, but Naina's defense of him, her loyalty, was both a balm and a weight. He felt conflicted. Naina had always been kind to him, patient, and understanding. She saw something in him that even he struggled to see in himself. But now, hearing the way people were talking behind their backs, Rahul couldn't help but question everything.

Before he could decide whether to walk in or turn around, the conversation inside shifted, Tanya clearly realizing that Naina wasn't going to back down. They changed the topic, moving on to something trivial, but Rahul wasn't listening anymore. His thoughts were louder than their voices.

He turned and walked away, his footsteps heavy and deliberate. He didn't look back.

As Rahul walked down the empty street outside the college, his mind was a whirlwind of thoughts. The night air was cool, but his skin felt hot, his face still burning with the embarrassment of what he had overheard. He shoved his hands deep into his pockets, his

fingers curling into fists as he kicked at the loose gravel beneath his feet.

"What was I thinking?" he muttered to himself, the words tumbling out before he could stop them. "What the hell was I thinking?"

He had always known that Naina was out of his league. From the moment he met her, it was clear. She was everything he wasn't—confident, outgoing, popular. She had the world at her feet, and people admired her for it. Meanwhile, he was... Rahul. The quiet, reserved guy who barely spoke to anyone, who kept his thoughts to himself, who preferred the company of books and history over the boisterous energy of college life.

But Naina had seen something in him. She had chosen to spend time with him, had pulled him into her orbit, and for a while, Rahul had let himself believe that maybe—just maybe—he wasn't so out of place in her life. He had started to feel comfortable around her, had begun to look forward to their time together in the club. But now, hearing what others thought, the illusion shattered.

"They're right," he thought bitterly, his footsteps growing heavier with each step. "I'm just dragging her down. I'm ruining her image. She deserves better than me."

The girls' words echoed in his head, growing louder with every step he took. He imagined what people must be saying when they saw them together—the whispers, the raised eyebrows, the smirks. He pictured the way they must be judging Naina for

spending time with him, wondering why she bothered. And the worst part was, they weren't wrong.

"She's popular," he thought. "She's beautiful. She's everything I'm not. And I'm just... there. A shadow. A mistake."

His mind spiraled further, each thought feeding into the next. He replayed every moment he had spent with Naina, every laugh they had shared, every conversation they had had, and in the harsh light of his self-doubt, it all seemed ridiculous. What had he been thinking? That he could actually be her friend? That he could belong in her world?

"You're an idiot, Rahul," he muttered to himself. "You should've known better."

The more he thought about it, the more convinced he became that he was right. He was a burden to Naina. A liability. Every time she defended him, every time she stood up for him, it was just another weight on her shoulders, another reason for people to question her judgment. He was ruining her reputation just by being near her.

And so, as Rahul walked through the empty streets, his mind made a decision. He would pull away. He would distance himself from her, for her own sake. He couldn't let her keep defending him, couldn't let her bear the brunt of the judgment that came with being associated with someone like him. It was for the best.

"It's the right thing to do," he told himself, though the words felt hollow. "She'll be better off without me."

The thought brought a sharp pain to his chest, but Rahul ignored it. He had to. This was about Naina, not him. She deserved to shine, to be admired and respected, without the baggage of someone like him holding her back.

Rahul walked on, the night stretching out before him, his thoughts swirling in the darkness. He had made up his mind. He would fade from her life, slowly, quietly, without a word. It would hurt, but it was the only way. For Naina's sake, he would disappear.

Chapter 8

A Heart in Haste

Rahul had been gradually distancing himself from Naina, choosing to communicate only through Nitin under the pretense of being overwhelmed by college work. Each time Nitin passed on the important documents or messages, Rahul felt a subtle pang of guilt, but he buried it deep. He had convinced himself that it was necessary to maintain distance, to focus on what he considered his priorities. Two days slipped by without a word between him and Naina.

On the third day, he found himself in the cafeteria with Nitin. It was an unusually quiet day, with only a few students scattered around the tables. Rahul and Nitin were sitting at their usual corner, silently munching on some snacks, when Rahul's heart suddenly skipped a beat. He saw her — Naina — walking toward them. Her hair was loose, flowing behind her, and she wore that same confident, carefree smile. She was coming toward them, but Rahul wasn't ready. His heart raced; his palms felt clammy. He couldn't face her, not yet.

Without thinking, Rahul grabbed his phone from the table. Pretending to be on a call, he mumbled hastily, "Yes, yes, I'm coming... Just give me five minutes." He got up in a hurry, avoiding Naina's gaze as he rushed out of the cafeteria. He didn't even give her a chance to speak.

Nitin, who had been quietly watching the whole situation unfold, raised an eyebrow, clearly puzzled by Rahul's behavior. He was about to say something but hesitated. Rahul wasn't acting like his usual composed self, and it was obvious to Nitin that something was going on. He wanted to ask, but he knew that Rahul would brush it off. So, he kept his thoughts to himself.

Naina, on the other hand, stood still for a moment, her smile fading slightly. She had come over to say hello, to break the strange silence that had grown between them in the past few days, but now she felt a bit lost. Rahul's sudden departure left her confused. She exchanged a brief glance with Nitin, her eyes searching for an answer, but Nitin just shrugged. Naina's face fell, her usual cheerful demeanor dimming for a second, and without saying much, she walked away quietly, heading toward the exit.

Outside, Rahul walked briskly, trying to steady his breathing. His heart was still pounding from the brief encounter. "What am I doing?" he muttered to himself as he slowed his pace. As he walked, guilt slowly crept up on him. He knew what he had done wasn't fair to Naina. She didn't deserve to be ignored like that. "I've been avoiding her for days," he thought, his mind racing with a mixture of guilt and self-doubt.

For the first time in a long while, Rahul felt something he wasn't used to: regret. Normally, when he distanced himself from people, it didn't bother him much. He was good at shutting off his emotions, at keeping people at arm's length. But this time, something was different. His thoughts kept circling back to Naina, to the look in her eyes when he had walked away. He knew he had probably hurt her feelings, and that realization gnawed at him more than he expected.

He stopped in his tracks, standing still in the middle of the walkway. For a moment, he debated whether to just keep walking or turn around and go back to the cafeteria. His heart tugged at him, telling him to go back, to apologize, to explain why he had been acting distant. "I can't just leave things like this," he thought to himself. Without giving it another second, he turned around and hurried back toward the cafeteria.

As he re-entered the cafeteria, his eyes immediately began searching for Naina. He scanned the room, but she was nowhere to be seen. His heart sank a little. She had left. He approached Nitin, who was still sitting at their table, nibbling absentmindedly on his snack.

"Where's Naina? She was just here, right?" Rahul asked, slightly out of breath.

Nitin gave him a quizzical look. "Yeah, she was here. But as soon as you pulled that little stunt, she made a face and left. I don't

know where she went,” Nitin replied, his tone a mixture of confusion and mild irritation.

Rahul felt a pang of guilt hit him even harder. He wasn’t used to feeling bad about ignoring people, but this time was different. This time, he felt it in his gut, and it showed on his face. Nitin noticed the change in Rahul’s demeanor and raised an eyebrow, realizing that something was genuinely bothering his friend.

Just as Nitin was about to say something, Rahul’s phone buzzed again. He glanced at the screen and saw that it was his family calling. Without thinking, he picked up the call.

“Yes, okay... I’ll leave today... I’m coming,” Rahul said into the phone, his expression suddenly growing serious. He hung up and turned to Nitin.

“What now?” Nitin asked, sensing that something urgent had come up.

“I just got a call from home. There’s been an emergency, and I have to leave immediately,” Rahul said, his mind now focused on the call. The thoughts of Naina slipped to the back of his mind as the urgency of the situation at home took precedence.

Nitin nodded, understanding the gravity of the situation. “Do you need me to drop you home?”

"Yeah, that would be great. I need to pack quickly and get to the station as soon as possible," Rahul replied, his mind racing with thoughts of what he needed to do.

Within minutes, Nitin and Rahul were speeding toward Rahul's flat. Rahul hurriedly packed his essentials, grabbing clothes, his travel documents, and his laptop, which he never traveled without. Time was ticking, and he knew he had to make it to the station quickly.

As they raced through the bustling streets of Pune, Rahul's mind was a whirlwind of thoughts. The call from home had shaken him, but in the back of his mind, he couldn't stop thinking about Naina. The image of her standing in the cafeteria, the hurt in her eyes, kept flashing in his mind. He tried to push it aside, focusing instead on the family emergency, but it lingered like a shadow in the corners of his thoughts.

By the time they reached Pune Railway Station, it was packed with people, as usual. The familiar hustle and bustle of the station filled the air with noise and chaos. Rahul had no time to waste. He grabbed his bag and sprinted inside, weaving his way through the crowd. Nitin stayed behind to park the bike, but Rahul knew he couldn't wait for him. Time was running out.

As he hurried through the crowded station, dodging travelers and luggage, Rahul scanned the platforms, trying to find his train. The announcement echoed through the loudspeakers: "The train scheduled for platform number 6 is now arriving." Rahul cursed under his breath. He was at platform 3.

Without a second thought, he bolted toward platform 6, his bag bouncing against his back as he ran. The station was swarming with people, and Rahul had to push his way through, slipping through the crowd like a snake. His heart pounded in his chest, and his mind raced with thoughts of his family and the emergency that awaited him at home.

When he finally reached platform 6, the train was pulling in. The general compartment, where he had to board, was packed. He squeezed his way toward the door, pushing past people to get inside. As he was about to climb aboard, he noticed a man and his small child struggling to get on the train. The child's foot slipped, and he was about to fall between the train and the platform.

Rahul's heart stopped for a moment. He screamed, "Stop!" as loud as he could. The passengers around him reacted quickly, pulling the child to safety just in time. Rahul let out a sigh of relief, his heart still pounding from the close call. For a moment, everything else faded away — the emergency, the station, even Naina. All that mattered in that moment was that the child was safe.

Rahul climbed aboard the train, his legs shaking slightly from the adrenaline. He managed to find a small seat near the window, a single side bench that he barely fit into. He sat down, exhausted, and placed his bag between his legs, making sure to keep it close. His laptop, the one thing he always took care of, was safe inside.

He pulled out his phone, expecting a message or another call from his family, but what he saw instead left him speechless: 67 missed calls from Naina. His heart skipped a beat. Why had she called him so many times? What did she want? Was she okay?

Before he could process it, his phone buzzed again. It was Naina, calling him for the 68th time. Rahul hesitated for a second but then picked up the call.

"Hi... what happened?" he asked, his voice quiet, unsure of what to expect.

"Rahul! Are you okay?!" Naina's voice was filled with concern and fear.

Rahul was taken aback. He hadn't expected her to sound so worried. "Yeah, I'm fine," he replied, confusion creeping into his voice. "Why are you asking?"

"You weren't picking up your phone. I called so many times... I thought something had happened to you," Naina said, her voice trembling slightly.

For the first time in a long while, Rahul felt a warmth he hadn't expected. He didn't know why, but her concern touched him.

"I'm okay. I'm on a train."

There's been an emergency at home, and I had to leave," he explained, his voice softening.

There was a long pause on the other end of the line. Finally, Naina spoke, her voice quieter than before. "I was just worried about you, Rahul... You've been so distant lately, and I didn't know what was going on."

Rahul closed his eyes, guilt washing over him once again. "I'm sorry, Naina," he said, the words coming out before he could stop them. "I didn't mean to ignore you... I've just had a lot on my mind."

Another pause, then Naina's voice came through, softer now. "It's okay, Rahul... Just take care of yourself, okay?"

Rahul nodded, even though she couldn't see him. "I will. Thank you, Naina."

And with that, the call ended.

Chapter 9

Shifting Horizons

The call ended with a click, but its echoes seemed to linger in the quiet train compartment. Rahul remained still, the phone still in his hand, its screen darkened. He sat motionless, staring blankly at the window in front of him. The scenery outside had changed since he first boarded the train. What had once been fields of bustling city life was now endless stretches of green, hills rolling gently in the distance, occasionally broken by small villages with the occasional lonely tree standing sentinel over the land. The rhythmic clatter of the train on the tracks filled the silence, but inside Rahul's head, a storm of thoughts swirled, loud and chaotic.

He tried to focus on the scene outside, watching the landscape go by, but it was difficult. The thoughts in his head kept intruding, kept pulling him back into the confines of his mind. Naina's voice was still fresh in his memory, the way she had said, *"Take care of yourself."* She had always been so careful with her words, so considerate, and yet every time she told him to take care, it did something to him. It wasn't just her concern—it was the weight of knowing someone cared so much. And now, after all that had happened, that simple phrase seemed to carry even more meaning.

He tried to shake off the feeling, but it clung to him like a shadow. In moments like these, Rahul couldn't help but reflect on how much his life had changed in the past few months. He had never anticipated meeting someone like Naina, let alone that she would have such an impact on him. And now, as he sat there, trying to think about anything but her, he found himself failing miserably. Every thought seemed to circle back to her, and to the conversation he had overheard in that dimly lit club—a conversation he wished he could forget.

He remembered the words of her friends, how casually they had spoken about him, how easily they had dismissed him as *"not good enough."* Rahul could still hear their voices, sharp and judgmental, as if they were sitting beside him now. He wasn't sure why it hurt so much, but it did. He had never asked for their approval, had never sought their opinions, and yet those words had stuck to him like a scar that wouldn't fade. And because of that, he had done what he thought was best—he had distanced himself from Naina, had kept her at arm's length even though every part of him wanted to be closer to her.

With a sigh, Rahul leaned back in his seat, his head resting against the cool glass of the window. The scenery outside had shifted again, the villages now replaced by wide fields that stretched into the horizon. He watched them pass, trying to let the monotony of the view calm his racing thoughts. But peace was elusive today. His mind kept returning to the other reason he was on this train, heading back to his hometown—the call from his father.

The message had been brief but serious: a land dispute had erupted over their family's property, and Rahul's presence was required to help resolve it. His father's voice had been stern, laced with the kind of urgency that left no room for hesitation. **"Your signature is needed, Rahul. This is a big problem, and we need to settle it as soon as possible."** Rahul could still hear the weight in his father's words, could still feel the tension that had settled in his chest when he heard the news.

Land disputes were common in their town, especially when it came to properties as old as theirs, but this one felt more serious, more personal. His family had lived on that land for generations, and now, there were threats of it being taken away, of legal battles that could drag on for months, if not years. And so, Rahul had left everything behind—his studies, his job, his life in Pune—to return home and help settle the matter.

The past few days had been a blur of meetings, phone calls, and tense discussions with lawyers and relatives. What had initially seemed like a simple problem had quickly spiraled into a complex legal battle, with documents to sign, claims to dispute, and endless paperwork to review. Rahul had felt the weight of responsibility pressing down on him every day, from the moment he woke up to the moment he lay in bed at night, too exhausted to sleep but too anxious to stay awake.

And yet, even amidst the chaos of the land dispute, there was a part of him that kept drifting back to Pune, back to the life he had temporarily left behind, and back to Naina. Every evening, after

the long meetings were done and the discussions were over, Rahul would retreat to his old room, the same room he had grown up in. It was a small space, but familiar and comforting, with a window beside his bed that overlooked the backyard. It was the kind of place that encouraged reflection, the kind of place where memories came flooding back whether you wanted them to or not.

Most nights, he would sit by the window, his legs curled up beneath him, staring out at the night sky. The stars were always brighter here than they were in the city, and on clear nights, the moon would cast a soft glow over the trees in the backyard. It was in these quiet moments that Rahul's mind would inevitably wander to Naina. He could picture her so clearly, as if she were sitting beside him, her eyes bright, her laughter filling the room.

There were so many times when he had picked up his phone, ready to call her or send her a message, just to hear her voice, just to feel a connection to her again. But every time, he stopped himself. He reminded himself of his decision, of the choice he had made to keep his distance, to protect both himself and her from the inevitable disappointment that would come if they got too close.

It wasn't easy, though. Every night, as he sat by that window, he missed her more than he was willing to admit. He missed the way she smiled, the way she could brighten a room just by walking into it. He missed their conversations, the easy way they could talk about anything and everything. But most of all, he missed the way

she made him feel—like he wasn't alone, like there was someone in the world who truly understood him.

Despite the pain of staying away, Rahul was determined. He had made a promise to himself, and he intended to keep it. He would be strong, would focus on his responsibilities, and would keep his distance from Naina. It was the only way to protect himself from the hurt that he knew was waiting for him if he let himself get too close.

The land dispute dragged on for nearly 10 days, each one feeling longer than the last. The tension in the house was palpable, with everyone on edge, waiting for the resolution that seemed so far away. But finally, after countless meetings and sleepless nights, the issue was resolved. The paperwork was signed, the legal matters settled, and the threat to their family's property was gone.

With the problem finally behind them, Rahul could breathe again. And yet, there was a part of him that felt strangely empty. The busyness of the past few days had kept his mind occupied, had given him something to focus on. Now, with the dispute over, there was nothing left to distract him from the thoughts he had been pushing away—the thoughts of Naina, and the life he had left behind in Pune.

The day before he was set to leave for Pune, Rahul found himself sitting with his mother in the kitchen, the two of them sharing a quiet moment. His mother had always been the heart of the family, her warmth and kindness a constant source of comfort. As they

sat there, sipping tea and talking about everything and nothing, Rahul was reminded of how much he missed her when he was away.

"You've grown so much, Rahul," she said softly, her eyes filled with pride and a touch of sadness. "It feels like just yesterday you were running around this house, causing all sorts of trouble."

Rahul smiled, the memory of his childhood flashing through his mind. "Those were simpler times," he replied, his voice tinged with nostalgia.

His mother reached across the table, placing her hand on his. "I'm proud of you, you know. You've become such a strong, capable young man."

Rahul's chest tightened at her words, the weight of her expectations pressing down on him. He nodded, not trusting himself to speak, afraid that if he did, the emotions would overwhelm him.

When the time came for him to leave, his mother hugged him tightly, her arms wrapped around him as if she didn't want to let go. "Take care of yourself, Rahul," she whispered, her voice thick with emotion. "And don't forget to call."

"I will, Ma," Rahul promised, his own voice barely audible as he fought back the lump in his throat.

His father, always more reserved, drove him to the station. The car ride was quiet, the two of them exchanging only a few words. But as they neared the station, his father spoke, his voice steady and calm. "We're proud of you, Rahul. You've handled everything well."

Rahul nodded, the weight of his father's words settling heavily on his shoulders. "Thank you, Dad."

At the station, they exchanged a brief goodbye, and soon Rahul found himself back on the train, heading toward Pune. This time, he had a reserved seat, and as he settled in, he felt a strange sense of relief. The past week had been exhausting, both physically and emotionally, and now that it was over, he could finally relax.

As the train began to move, Rahul stared out the window once more. The familiar landscape of his hometown slowly disappeared, replaced by the vast fields and rolling hills that led back to

As the train picked up speed, Rahul settled into his seat, the rhythmic sway of the carriage gently rocking him as the world outside started to blur. His gaze was fixed on the window, the glass a barrier through which he could only observe the changing landscape. The scenery was a mix of greens and browns, with the occasional burst of color from blooming flowers and distant, hazy buildings. But Rahul's focus wasn't on the view itself; it was on what lay beyond it—the life he had left behind in Pune, and the one he was returning to.

Naina's image hovered in his mind, vivid and unyielding. He could picture her easily—her laughter, her smile, the way her eyes lit up when she spoke. The thought of seeing her, even from a distance, brought a pang of longing to his chest. He knew he wasn't ready to confront her, to rekindle the complicated feelings that had been left unresolved, but the desire to see her, to catch a glimpse of her in the bustling streets of Pune, was overpowering. The idea of watching her from afar, without engaging or speaking, seemed to be the only way he could reconcile his emotions with the reality of their situation.

Rahul's mind drifted further, wrestling with the weight of his parents' expectations. They had always dreamed of him achieving great things, of making a mark in the world. Their hopes had shaped his path, guiding him through his studies and career. But now, as he returned to Pune, he was acutely aware of the gap between their aspirations and his current reality. He had become the person they wanted him to be, but at what cost?

The responsibilities he had shouldered for his family—the land dispute, the pressures of resolving it—had momentarily pulled him away from his own dreams and desires. The sense of duty was heavy, a constant reminder of the sacrifices he had made and the direction his life had taken. Rahul had always been the reliable one, the one who could be counted on to handle things, to meet expectations. But with each passing day, he questioned whether he was living the life he truly wanted, or if he was simply fulfilling a role that had been assigned to him.

He thought about his own dreams—those fleeting, often dismissed aspirations that lingered at the edges of his consciousness. The hobbies he once loved, the passions he had set aside, all seemed to fade into the background as the demands of life took precedence. He wondered how he could reconcile these dreams with his current reality, how he could find a way to balance the expectations of others with the pursuits of his own heart.

As the train continued its journey, Rahul felt himself sinking deeper into his thoughts, the landscape outside becoming a mere backdrop to the turmoil within. The shifting views of the countryside seemed to echo his own shifting emotions—one moment calm and serene, the next turbulent and restless. The train's motion was almost hypnotic, a rhythm that matched the rise and fall of his introspection.

The moments of solitude on the train were both a blessing and a curse. They offered him a chance to reflect, to ponder his life's direction and his relationship with Naina. But they also left him alone with his doubts and uncertainties. The quiet of the train compartment, punctuated only by the occasional sound of the wheels on the tracks, was both comforting and isolating. It was a space where he could think without interruption, yet it was also a reminder of his solitude.

Rahul's thoughts wandered back to his recent visit home. The brief time he spent there, amid the familial warmth and the chaos of the land dispute, had been a whirlwind of emotions. He

remembered the comforting presence of his mother, the stern but loving encouragement from his father, and the quiet, reflective moments spent alone in his old room. Each memory was tinged with a mix of nostalgia and regret—a reminder of the life he had temporarily left behind and the one he was returning to.

The train journey, though seemingly mundane, was a metaphor for Rahul's internal voyage—a transition from one phase of his life to another, a movement from the familiar to the unknown. As he gazed out the window, the train's passage through the changing landscapes mirrored his own passage through a period of self-discovery and decision-making.

With each passing mile, Rahul's mind continued to churn, wrestling with the complexities of his life. The train would soon reach its destination, and with it, a return to the life he had left behind. He knew that upon arriving in Pune, he would be faced with the reality of his decisions, the weight of his responsibilities, and the lingering question of how he would navigate his relationship with Naina.

For now, as the train sped toward its destination, Rahul was lost in his thoughts, the outside world a distant blur. His reflections on life, love, and personal dreams were his only companions in this journey, and as the train continued its steady course, he could only hope that the answers he sought would come to him along the way.

Chapter 10

Reconnection & Reflection

After spending some time away from college, Rahul finally returned to his rented flat in Pune. The trip had been full of emotional turbulence and self-reflection, leading him to contemplate his life, responsibilities, and the relationships that mattered to him. Rahul had decided not to call Nitin for assistance, preferring instead to navigate the crowded PMT buses and bustling streets on his own. He arrived at his flat in the early hours of the morning, feeling a mix of exhaustion and resolve.

Upon reaching his flat, Rahul quickly freshened up and prepared himself for the day ahead. The routine of getting ready—showering, dressing, and gathering his belongings—was oddly comforting, providing him a sense of normalcy amidst the chaos of recent events. He was determined to face the day with a clear mind, ready to confront the issues that had been weighing heavily on him.

Rahul arrived at college and made his way to the food court, where he hoped to catch up with his friends. To his surprise, he found

Nitin and Naina sitting together at a table. They were engaged in an animated conversation, their faces lit up with the kind of ease that suggested a deep connection. Rahul's appearance did not go unnoticed by Naina. Her expression shifted from surprise to a complex mixture of relief, concern, and perhaps a touch of confusion.

Without missing a beat, Naina looked directly at Rahul and asked the question that had been on her mind for days. Her voice was tinged with a mix of hurt and urgency. "Rahul, why have you been ignoring me? We're friends, aren't we? I don't understand why you haven't been in touch. Please, can you tell me what's going on?"

The directness of her question caught Rahul off guard. He could see the pain in her eyes, and it made his heart ache. The confrontation was intense, and it was clear that Naina had been deeply affected by his sudden withdrawal. Rahul felt a surge of guilt and regret. He knew he owed her an explanation, and he realized that he needed to address the issue directly.

Nitin, sensing the gravity of the situation, decided to step away to give Rahul and Naina the space they needed. He quietly excused himself, mentioning that he had some work to attend to. This left Rahul and Naina alone, providing them with the opportunity to have a much-needed heart-to-heart conversation.

Rahul took a deep breath and began to open up. He spoke candidly about the internal struggles he had been facing. He explained the emotional and psychological turmoil that had been consuming

him—his overthinking, his sense of responsibility, and the weight of various problems that had been burdening him. It was a moment of vulnerability for Rahul, as he laid bare his fears, doubts, and the reasons behind his recent behavior.

Naina listened attentively, her initial frustration gradually giving way to empathy and understanding. As Rahul spoke, she reached out and placed a reassuring hand on his. Her gesture was one of comfort and support. "Rahul," she said softly, "I don't care about the reasons or excuses. What matters to me is that you're my friend, and I want to be there for you. I want things to be okay between us. You don't have to worry about anything. Just be yourself, and let's move forward."

Naina's words were a balm to Rahul's troubled soul. Her reassurance and unwavering support provided him with a sense of relief and comfort. Rahul felt a profound sense of gratitude as he realized that their friendship was strong enough to withstand the challenges they had faced.

They both decided to move past the misunderstandings and rebuild their connection. Naina expressed her desire to maintain their friendship and emphasized that she did not want to lose him as a friend. Rahul agreed, and they spent the rest of the time talking about their recent experiences. Their conversation was punctuated with laughter and shared memories, allowing them to reconnect on a deeper level.

As the day progressed, Naina invited Rahul to join her for coffee. Despite the fact that Rahul was not particularly fond of coffee, he agreed to accompany her. The act of sharing a cup of coffee was a symbol of his commitment to their friendship and his willingness to be there for her. They went to a nearby café, where they enjoyed their time together. The café atmosphere, combined with their engaging conversation, helped to restore a sense of normalcy and happiness.

After their coffee outing, Rahul walked Naina to the bus stop. They continued to chat and laugh, and the tension that had previously existed seemed to melt away. When the bus arrived, Naina thanked Rahul for spending time with her and bid him farewell. Rahul watched as she boarded the bus and waved goodbye, feeling a renewed sense of contentment and connection.

As Rahul made his way back to his flat, his thoughts were a mix of introspection and contemplation. He reflected on the events of the day and the nature of his feelings for Naina. He wondered if she saw him as more than a friend or if his own emotions had clouded his judgment. Despite his inner conflict, he resolved to maintain their friendship and not let his uncertainties disrupt their bond.

The journey back to his flat was a time of reflection. Rahul thought about his life, his responsibilities, and the expectations placed upon him by his parents. He pondered the dreams and aspirations they had for him and how he was balancing those with his own desires and uncertainties. As he reached his flat, he felt a sense of

resolve and determination to face the challenges ahead with a clearer perspective.

The days that followed were a blend of routine and introspection. Rahul continued with his academic responsibilities and spent time with his friends, including Naina. Their renewed friendship provided him with a sense of stability and support, helping him navigate the complexities of his life.

When it was time for Rahul to return to his home for a family matter, he was once again reminded of the importance of family and the emotional ties that bound him. As he prepared for his journey back to Pune, he experienced a mix of anticipation and apprehension. He hoped that his time away had strengthened his connections and provided him with the clarity he needed.

In the end, Rahul's journey was not just about resolving conflicts and mending relationships; it was also about understanding himself and finding his way in the midst of life's challenges. As he looked out the train window during his return journey, he felt a renewed sense of purpose and hope. The path ahead was still uncertain, but he was ready to face it with a clearer perspective and a strengthened sense of self.

Chapter 11

Bonded Triumph

As the semester neared its conclusion, the campus buzzed with a palpable sense of urgency and anticipation. Students were hurrying to complete final projects, submit reports, and prepare for exams. The air was thick with the smell of determination and the sound of frenzied activity. For Rahul and Naina, this period was especially critical as they prepared for the final presentation of their club report—an undertaking that had consumed a significant portion of their time and effort over the past few weeks.

The weeks leading up to this moment had been intense. Rahul and Naina had dedicated countless hours to crafting a detailed and well-researched report. Their commitment to excellence was evident in every aspect of their work. They meticulously gathered data, analyzed their findings, and presented their insights in a comprehensive manner. Their collaboration had been both challenging and rewarding, strengthening their partnership and deepening their bond.

Naina's role in the project had been pivotal. She had been a steadfast ally, working alongside Rahul to ensure that their report

met the highest standards. Their late-night work sessions were marked by focused discussions and shared determination. As the deadline approached, their efforts reached a crescendo of activity, culminating in the final touches on their report. The sense of accomplishment they felt was immense, knowing that their hard work was about to be showcased.

The day of the presentation arrived with a mixture of excitement and nervousness. Rahul, ever the professional, dressed formally for the occasion. His attire was crisp and polished, reflecting the seriousness with which he approached the presentation. Naina, ever supportive, was by his side, ready to offer moral support and encouragement. Her presence was a comforting constant for Rahul, especially during moments of high pressure.

As Rahul walked into the professor's lab, his mind raced with thoughts and expectations. The lab was abuzz with the chatter of students and the low hum of academic discourse. The professors, with their sharp eyes and discerning minds, were poised to evaluate the work presented before them. Rahul took a deep breath, steeling himself for the task at hand.

The presentation commenced with Rahul confidently navigating through his slides. Each slide was a testament to the extensive work that had gone into the report. He spoke with clarity and conviction, addressing each aspect of the project with precision. The professors, known for their rigorous questioning, posed a series of challenging queries. Rahul responded to each question with thorough and well-considered answers, demonstrating his

deep understanding of the subject matter. The room was filled with an air of respect as Rahul handled each query with poise and expertise.

When the presentation concluded, Rahul emerged from the lab with a broad smile on his face. The sense of relief and joy was evident, as he had successfully communicated the essence of their work and impressed the evaluators. He was eager to share this moment with Naina, who had been waiting outside for him.

In his excitement, Rahul almost moved to give Naina a celebratory hug. However, as he approached her, he was momentarily struck by a wave of awkwardness. The moment felt unexpectedly charged, and he found himself hesitating. Naina, sensing his hesitation, broke the silence with a cheerful suggestion. "Let's go to the college cafeteria and have coffee. It's time to celebrate!"

Rahul agreed, though he mentioned that he needed to stop by the library to pick up some books. They made their way to the library together, where Rahul retrieved a substantial stack of books related to his research. The library, a sanctuary for scholars, was a familiar environment for Rahul. As he was gathering the books, the librarian—a friendly young woman—attempted to engage him in conversation, and her intentions were clear. Rahul, focused on his task, remained courteous but distant.

Naina, observing the interaction from a distance, felt a pang of jealousy. The librarian's flirtatious behavior stirred a sense of possessiveness within her. Despite her discomfort, Naina chose to

remain silent, not wanting to disrupt the day's positive atmosphere.

With an armful of books and a few balancing precariously in his hands, Rahul and Naina made their way to the cafeteria. They arrived at a bustling eatery filled with students enjoying their breaks. Rahul placed the books on a table and ordered a coffee. Naina, curious about the extensive collection of books, inquired about their purpose.

Rahul explained that he was working on research papers and a thesis related to his passion for archaeology and history. The conversation flowed naturally as Rahul shared his enthusiasm for his academic pursuits. Naina listened with genuine interest, her curiosity piqued by Rahul's dedication to his field.

As they enjoyed their coffee, Naina took the opportunity to offer her help. She suggested that she could assist in carrying some of the books. Rahul appreciated the gesture, and together, they left the cafeteria and headed towards the photo studio. Naina needed to pick up prints from an event she had participated in a few months ago. The prints had been delayed, and she had forgotten to retrieve them earlier.

On the way to the photo studio, their conversation turned to their upcoming schedules. They discussed the imminent end-of-term exams and the heavy workload that lay ahead. Rahul would be occupied with his thesis work for the next week and then shift his focus to exam preparation. Naina, on the other hand, had to

balance her studies with preparations for an upcoming event. They both recognized that their time together would be limited due to their respective commitments.

Despite the busy schedules, they motivated each other to stay focused and excel in their tasks. Their conversation was filled with optimism and encouragement, reflecting their mutual support and understanding. By the time they reached the photo studio, Naina had retrieved the prints, and they prepared to head back to the bus stop.

As the day transitioned to evening, the sky was painted with hues of orange and pink. The sun dipped below the horizon, casting a warm glow over the city. Naina handed the books back to Rahul, and they shared a warm smile. It was clear that their time together had been both enjoyable and meaningful.

With the sky darkening and the day drawing to a close, Naina and Rahul knew it was time to part ways. They exchanged their final goodbyes, their smiles reflecting the positive and supportive nature of their friendship. Naina watched as Rahul walked away towards his bus stop, while she turned in the opposite direction.

Rahul's thoughts were a blend of reflections and anticipations as he made his way home. The time spent with Naina had been a highlight of his busy schedule, and he felt a sense of gratitude for her companionship. The journey back to his flat was filled with contemplation, as he looked forward to the challenges and opportunities that awaited him.

As Rahul walked, he replayed the day's events in his mind. The presentation, the interaction with Naina, and the conversation they had shared were all fresh in his thoughts. He felt a sense of accomplishment and satisfaction, knowing that the day had been a success. The time with Naina had been a source of joy and comfort, and he looked forward to their next meeting with anticipation.

In the end, the day had been a testament to their friendship and the bond they shared. Despite the busyness and the demands of their schedules, the moments they spent together had been meaningful and memorable. The smiles they exchanged were a reflection of their genuine connection, and the anticipation of future interactions left them both with a sense of contentment and optimism.

Chapter 12

Academic Marathon

As the semester progressed towards its climax, Rahul found himself enveloped in the demanding world of research and academic deadlines. The weeks preceding the final exams were a whirlwind of activity. Rahul was dedicated to producing a series of research papers and case studies that were crucial for his academic and professional aspirations. His commitment was unwavering, and he devoted every waking moment to his work, often sacrificing personal time and social interactions.

Each day was a battle against the clock as Rahul labored over his research. The pressures of deadlines and the complexity of his topics kept him at his desk from early morning until late at night. To stay motivated and focused, Rahul frequently reached out to Naina. Her encouraging words and the sight of her photo on his phone were his anchors, helping him push through the most challenging moments. Her support was a constant source of comfort and inspiration, fueling his determination to complete his tasks.

As the week drew to a close, Rahul's efforts bore fruit. He managed to finalize his case studies and submit them to various government archaeological departments. With his work complete, Rahul allowed himself a well-deserved break. Exhausted but

satisfied, he took a much-needed night's sleep to recharge his weary body and mind.

In the middle of the night, Naina, ever considerate, called Rahul to check on his progress. Despite the late hour and his drowsy state, Rahul appreciated the gesture. He answered her call with a sleepy voice, informing her that he had completed and submitted his work. After a brief chat, he ended the call and returned to his slumber. Naina, who was also busy preparing for her exams and an upcoming event, had been a pillar of support throughout Rahul's academic endeavor.

With only a week remaining before the exams, both Rahul and Naina were deep in their preparations. Rahul was focused on studying for his exams, with Nitin lending a helping hand. The partnership proved beneficial, as they worked through mock tests and reviewed key concepts together.

The day of the first exam arrived, bringing with it a mixture of excitement and anxiety. Rahul had planned to meet Naina before the exam for a brief exchange of good luck wishes. However, as fate would have it, Rahul was running late. He hurried to the college, arriving just as the exam had begun. Despite the delay, he managed to enter the examination hall and complete his paper. The exam went reasonably well, though Rahul felt a sense of urgency to connect with Naina as soon as possible.

After the exam, Rahul made a beeline for the arts department, where he knew Naina would be. His face lit up with a wide grin

when he spotted her. "Heyyy! Hi!" he exclaimed, his enthusiasm palpable. They shared a moment of relief, discussing how their papers had gone. Their mutual support was a comforting balm amidst the stress of the exams.

The duo decided to walk to the bus stand together, savoring the brief respite from their academic pressures. Their conversations were light-hearted, and they reveled in the camaraderie of their shared experience. The exam period was a demanding time, but their moments together were a cherished escape.

As the exams continued over the next few days, Rahul and Naina's routine involved late-night study sessions and strategic breaks. They both looked forward to the end of the exam period with eager anticipation. The thought of having their schedules clear and spending more time together was a source of motivation.

On the penultimate day of exams, the atmosphere on campus was a mix of jubilation and exhaustion. Students celebrated the end of their last paper, their voices echoing through the hallways. Rahul, however, found himself in a somber mood. Naina had sent him a text earlier, apologizing for not being able to meet up due to her rehearsal for an event. She had mentioned that she would be late, and Rahul was disappointed.

Navigating through the throng of students celebrating their academic victories, Rahul made his way back home. The joy around him contrasted with his own feelings of melancholy.

Arriving at his flat, he collapsed onto his bed, feeling drained and despondent.

Just as he was sinking into a state of fatigue, his phone buzzed with a new notification. It was a message from Naina. Rahul's face brightened as he read her text. Despite her earlier apology, Naina had proposed a plan to make up for their missed meeting. She suggested that they meet the following day at 11 a.m. in a local park for a leisurely catch-up and lunch.

The prospect of spending time with Naina, coupled with the promise of a pleasant outing, lifted Rahul's spirits. His earlier disappointment melted away, replaced by a wide smile and a renewed sense of excitement. The thought of seeing Naina and enjoying a relaxed day together was the perfect remedy for his weary soul.

With a heart full of anticipation, Rahul looked forward to their planned meeting. The prospect of sharing a day with Naina, away from the pressures of exams and academic responsibilities, filled him with joy. It was a reminder of the meaningful connection they shared and the simple pleasures of spending time with someone who mattered.

As Rahul prepared for bed that night, his thoughts were filled with images of their upcoming day together. The end of the exams and the promise of their meeting offered a hopeful glimpse of brighter days ahead. With a contented sigh, Rahul drifted off to sleep,

eagerly awaiting the next morning and the chance to reconnect with Naina.

Chapter 13

Love and Loss

The morning sun stretched its warm, golden fingers across the city, heralding the arrival of a perfect day. The sky was a brilliant canvas of soft blues and gentle whites, adorned with wispy clouds drifting lazily. The air was crisp, carrying a faint scent of blooming flowers from nearby gardens, promising a day of clarity and joy. As the world outside basked in the tranquility of a new day, Rahul awoke with a sense of renewed hope and excitement.

Today was a significant day for Rahul, marked by the promise of a peaceful reunion with Naina after the grueling period of exams that had kept them apart. The nights of relentless studying and academic stress had finally come to an end, and the prospect of spending time with Naina was a beacon of happiness. Rahul's heart raced with anticipation as he got out of bed, a smile already tugging at the corners of his lips.

He shuffled to his desk, where his phone lay, buzzing softly with a new notification. With a mix of curiosity and eagerness, Rahul unlocked his phone and opened his email. His eyes widened in disbelief and joy as he read the acceptance email from the archaeological department. His research paper and case study had been reviewed and praised, and he was offered a trainee position. The department was impressed by his work and extended an invitation to join them, with the possibility of future

employment as a full-time researcher or professor. The offer came with a stipend, addressing all his financial concerns and providing a promising pathway for his career.

Overwhelmed with happiness, Rahul's first instinct was to share this incredible news with his mother. He dialed her number with trembling fingers, his voice filled with excitement as he recounted the details of the email. His mother's joyful reaction and heartfelt congratulations were a source of immense comfort. She was overjoyed for him, and her pride was palpable. Rahul promised to share the news with Naina in person, wanting to see her reaction firsthand.

As he prepared for his meeting with Naina, Rahul's mood was buoyant. He meticulously picked out his outfit, opting for a simple yet stylish look. He settled on a t-shirt paired with a jacket that he had recently rediscovered. The jacket added a touch of sophistication to his appearance, and he couldn't help but admire how well he looked in it. His reflection in the mirror revealed a handsome, confident young man ready to embrace the day.

In the midst of his preparation, Rahul noticed a stack of books strewn around his room. These were research materials he had been too preoccupied to return to the library. As he gathered them, he came across a familiar envelope tucked away in one of the books. Curiosity piqued, he picked it up and examined it closely. The envelope bore a logo from a photographer's studio—one he recognized as having been given to Naina.

Carefully, Rahul opened the envelope and began to sift through the contents. To his amazement, it contained photographs of Naina at a cultural event. His breath caught as he saw images of her in a stunning white dress—the same dress he had glimpsed on that rainy night. The photos captured Naina in various poses, anchoring the event with grace and poise. Among the images was the scarf he had seen her with that night.

Rahul's heart raced as the pieces of the puzzle fell into place. The realization struck him with breathtaking clarity—Naina was the girl he had seen under the leafless peepal tree, the same girl who had unknowingly touched his heart that rainy evening. The world suddenly felt incredibly small and interconnected.

As he sat there, holding the photographs and the scarf, Rahul's emotions surged like a powerful tide. He marveled at how fate had intertwined their lives in such a profound way. The realization that Naina was the same girl from that night made his feelings for her even more intense. He had been in love with her all along, without even knowing it. This newfound understanding only deepened his affection.

With a heart brimming with love and excitement, Rahul knew he had to share his feelings with Naina. He envisioned their meeting with even more significance, his proposal now tinged with the profound connection he had just discovered. He retrieved the scarf from his trunk, rolling it gently in his hands as he prepared to meet her. The scarf, once a symbol of a fleeting moment, had now become a tangible link between their past and present.

At 10:30 a.m., Rahul texted Naina, confirming that he was on his way. He was practically bouncing with anticipation, eager to see her. As he left his house, every step felt lighter, every breath sweeter. He was determined to make the day unforgettable.

Rahul's excitement was palpable as he approached the park where they had planned to meet. The anticipation of revealing his feelings and the joy of finally spending time with Naina filled him with an overwhelming sense of happiness. The morning sun continued to shine brightly, casting a warm glow over the park and adding to the magic of the day.

As Rahul neared the meeting spot, he couldn't help but think about how perfect this day had become. It wasn't just about the acceptance email or the new opportunities—it was about the incredible realization of his love for Naina and the chance to make his feelings known. Today was shaping up to be one of the most memorable days of his life, and he was ready to embrace it fully.

The morning was as promising as Rahul had imagined it—an idyllic backdrop for the culmination of months of longing and anticipation. The sun rose with a gentle grace, casting a warm golden light across the park's sprawling greenery. Dew still clung to the grass, and the air was crisp and invigorating. Birds chirped

melodiously, their songs blending with the distant hum of the city waking up.

Rahul arrived at the park with a heart full of joy, having spent weeks preparing for this very moment. He opted to wait outside, standing near a traffic signal at the entrance. His excitement was palpable, each passing second amplifying his nervous energy. The world seemed to pause around him, the only thing that mattered was seeing Naina, the girl who had captured his heart and made the last few months meaningful.

As he waited, he couldn't help but admire the serene beauty of the park. The sunlight dappled through the trees, creating patterns of light and shadow on the pathway. Flowers bloomed in vibrant hues, their colors a stark contrast to the calm greenery. The entire scene felt like a painting, a perfect prelude to the day he had eagerly anticipated.

He pulled out his phone and dialed Naina's number, his fingers trembling with both excitement and anxiety. The familiar sound of her voice on the other end of the line instantly soothed him. "I'm just on the other side of the road," she said, her tone light and cheerful, filled with the same anticipation that Rahul felt.

His eyes darted around the area, searching for her. And then he saw her. Across the street, standing like an ethereal vision, was Naina. She wore the same white dress she had worn that rainy night. The dress flowed elegantly, accentuating her gracefulness as she stood there. Her hair fell in soft waves around her

shoulders, and the sunlight caught her features, illuminating her with an almost otherworldly glow. She was a vision of beauty, so exquisite that Rahul could hardly tear his eyes away.

Unable to contain his emotions, Rahul spoke into the phone, his voice full of admiration, "Naina, you look absolutely beautiful."

Her laughter, light and melodic, reached his ears through the phone. "Thank you, Rahul. I'm almost there. I have so much to tell you—things I've wanted to say for a long time. I need to share something very important with you."

Rahul's heart swelled with love and anticipation. "I can't wait to hear it. I have something incredibly important to tell you too. It's one of the most significant things in my life."

As Naina began to cross the street, Rahul's gaze remained fixed on her. The anticipation of their meeting was so intense that it felt like the world was holding its breath. But in a heartbeat, everything changed.

A truck roared down the street, its engine growling ominously. The truck appeared seemingly out of nowhere, and in a horrifying moment, it struck Naina with a violent impact. Rahul's world shattered instantly. He watched in stunned silence as Naina was thrown to the ground, her body crumpling onto the asphalt. The once-pristine white dress was now smeared with blood, the stark red a horrific contrast to the purity of the fabric. Blood trickled

from a wound on her head, a vivid reminder of the brutality of the accident.

Panic surged through Rahul like a tidal wave. His legs felt like lead, but he forced himself to move, rushing to Naina's side. People began to gather, their shocked whispers mingling with the sounds of sirens in the distance. Rahul was paralyzed by the scene before him. He knelt beside Naina, her form so still and broken, and he reached out to her. His hands, now stained with her blood, trembled uncontrollably as he cradled her head.

"Naina, please, please wake up," he cried, his voice raw and anguished. "I love you, Naina. Please don't leave me. I need you to hear me. I want to tell you that I love you." His pleas were desperate, the words coming from a place of profound sorrow and fear.

The ambulance arrived, its siren slicing through the chaos and despair. Paramedics moved swiftly, their movements practiced and efficient as they placed Naina on a stretcher and loaded her into the vehicle. Rahul, his heart heavy with dread, followed closely, unable to tear himself away from her side.

Inside the ambulance, the reality of the situation became even more harrowing. Rahul's sobs filled the air, a heartbreaking counterpoint to the clinical efficiency of the paramedics. He held Naina's hand, feeling her pulse weaken with each passing moment. "Naina, please, stay with me," he begged, his voice breaking with

every word. "I love you so much. Please, don't go. I need you to stay with me. I need you to hear me."

Naina's breathing was faint and labored, each breath a slow, agonizing struggle. Her eyes remained closed, and her face, though still beautiful, was pale and disfigured by the blood. The sight of her in such a condition was almost too much for Rahul to bear. He watched as the light slowly faded from her face, his heart aching with each labored breath she took.

As the ambulance sped towards the hospital, Rahul's cries of despair filled the vehicle. The joy of the morning had turned into a nightmare of unimaginable proportions. The world outside seemed to blur into a haze of grief and confusion, and Rahul's mind was consumed by the only thought that mattered—Naina's life hanging in the balance.

He clung to the hope that the paramedics' skills would be enough to save her, but the weight of reality was heavy. The once-vibrant day now felt like a cruel joke, the contrast between the morning's beauty and the tragedy that had unfolded was stark and unbearable.

As they reached the hospital, Rahul's cries of anguish continued, his heart breaking with each passing second. The ambulance doors swung open, and the medical team rushed Naina into the emergency room. Rahul was left standing outside, his tears flowing freely, his heart shattered. All he could do was wait, his mind replaying the events in a loop of torment and sorrow.

Chapter 14

Shattered Hopes

The chaos of the hospital was overwhelming. The bright lights, hurried footsteps, and the murmur of voices blurred into the background as Rahul's world spun out of control. After Naina was rushed into the ICU, Rahul stood in the sterile waiting room, his heart thudding loudly in his chest, the ringing in his ears growing louder with every passing second. His clothes were stained with Naina's blood, the reminder of the accident haunting him relentlessly.

A doctor, stern but concerned, approached him. "Are you a relative?" he asked, his voice cutting through the haze that clouded Rahul's mind.

Rahul's throat tightened as he tried to find words. "I'm... I'm not family, but I..." His voice cracked, and his eyes welled with tears. The weight of the moment was suffocating, and the truth of how much Naina meant to him flooded his heart. "I love her."

The doctor nodded, sensing the urgency in Rahul's voice. "We need to operate immediately," he explained, his expression grim. "She's got severe internal bleeding in her brain, and if we don't act fast, she might not survive."

Rahul felt the floor drop from beneath him. It was as if the world had stopped spinning, and all that remained was this unbearable moment. "Do whatever it takes," he stammered. "Just... save her."

"There's no time to lose, but we need a guardian's consent to proceed with the surgery," the doctor informed him, his voice urgent.

Rahul's mind raced. Naina's parents—they weren't here. They were miles away, unaware of the nightmare that had unfolded. Without hesitation, Rahul fumbled for his phone, his trembling hands struggling to find the contacts. He dialed Naina's parents, his heart pounding in his ears as the phone rang.

When her father answered, Rahul could hardly breathe. "Uncle, it's Rahul," he said, his voice barely above a whisper. "Something terrible has happened... Naina, she's been in an accident. She's in the ICU... They need to operate immediately."

There was a stunned silence on the other end of the line before Naina's father spoke, his voice thick with disbelief. "We'll take the next flight out. We'll be there by evening. Please... take care of her until we arrive."

Rahul's heart clenched in his chest. "They need to operate now," he pleaded. "She might not make it if they wait. Please, we need someone to authorize the surgery."

Naina's father paused, his voice breaking. "There's her aunt, who lives in Pune. Call her. She'll be able to sign the papers."

Rahul nodded, tears streaming down his face. He hung up and quickly dialed Naina's aunt. His voice cracked as he explained everything. The weight of his words seemed too heavy for his heart to bear, but there was no time for hesitation.

Soon after, Naina's aunt rushed to the hospital, her face pale with shock. She signed the consent forms, and the medical team whisked Naina into the operating room. The doors to the operation theater closed with a finality that left Rahul feeling helpless. His world narrowed to the cold, unforgiving hallway where he now stood.

Hours stretched on like an eternity. Rahul paced up and down, his mind racing through a thousand memories, each one more painful than the last. He couldn't shake the image of Naina lying on the road, blood seeping from her head, her body motionless. He couldn't breathe, couldn't think.

Nitin arrived soon after, his face etched with concern. "Rahul," he whispered, pulling his friend into a tight hug. But Rahul barely noticed. He was drowning in a sea of pain and fear, his chest heaving as sobs wracked his body.

"They have to save her, Nitin," Rahul choked out, his voice barely recognizable. "She can't... she can't leave me. I didn't even get to tell her I love her..."

Nitin tried his best to console him, offering water, but Rahul shook his head violently, his body trembling with emotion. His hands balled into fists, and he fell to his knees in despair. The pressure in his chest was unbearable, suffocating.

Minutes passed, or maybe it was hours. Rahul couldn't tell anymore. He stared at the closed doors of the operation theater, willing them to open, praying that the next time they did, the news would be good.

But then a nurse came out, her face strained. She was carrying bags of blood into the theater, and Rahul felt a wave of nausea wash over him. His stomach lurched, and he barely managed to stop himself from collapsing again.

"What's happening?!" he cried out, grabbing the nurse's arm, his voice hoarse with desperation. "Please... is she okay? Will she be okay?"

The nurse, trying her best to remain professional, glanced at him with sympathetic eyes. "We're doing everything we can," she said gently before slipping back into the theater.

Rahul collapsed onto a nearby chair, his whole body shaking. He couldn't stop the tears anymore. They fell freely, his sobs uncontrollable. "Naina, please... don't leave me," he whispered, his hands trembling as he clutched the blood-stained corner of his shirt. "I can't do this without you. I love you... I love you so much."

Nitin sat beside him, silent but steady, his hand on Rahul's shoulder as the minutes ticked by. But nothing could calm the storm of emotions that raged inside Rahul. Each passing second felt like another dagger to his heart. The not knowing, the helplessness—it was driving him to the edge of madness.

Just when he thought he couldn't bear it any longer, one of the doctors emerged from the operation room, his scrubs stained with blood, his face pale with exhaustion. Rahul shot to his feet, his legs unsteady as he stumbled towards him.

"How is she?!" Rahul practically screamed, his voice breaking. His eyes were wild with desperation, his heart pounding so hard it hurt.

The doctor's face was grave. "The operation is still ongoing," he said quietly, "but... her condition is critical. We're doing everything we can, but there's a lot of internal bleeding."

At that moment, the weight of the world seemed to crash down on Rahul. His knees gave way, and before he could process what was happening, everything went black. His body collapsed to the ground, unconscious from the overwhelming grief and emotional exhaustion.

Nitin rushed to his side, calling for help as nurses rushed over to lift Rahul. But even as they tended to him, Nitin could only think of

his friend's heartache, of the unbearable pain Rahul would wake up to.

Chapter 15

A New Dawn

Rahul's world had been a blur of chaos and panic for the last several hours, but now, as he sat beside Naina in that cold hospital room, everything seemed to slow down. He couldn't remember the last time he had been so close to her, holding her hand in his, feeling the warmth of her skin. His body ached from exhaustion, and his mind was a storm of emotions—fear, relief, love, and everything in between.

He had been on the brink of losing her. The thought alone made his chest tighten, and for a moment, he closed his eyes, fighting back the tears that threatened to spill once again. How close had he come to living a life without her? A life where her laughter didn't brighten his darkest days, where her voice wasn't the melody that brought peace to his restless soul?

But she was here now. She was alive. The doctors had done everything they could, and she had pulled through. Naina had always been strong, stronger than he ever was, and she had fought her way back to him.

The doctor's words still echoed in his ears: "She's out of danger now, but it will take time for her to regain consciousness. She should wake up by tomorrow."

Tomorrow. That word had never felt so distant. Rahul knew he would wait for her, no matter how long it took. He wasn't going to leave her side—not now, not ever. He gently squeezed her hand, careful not to wake her. The rhythmic beeping of the machines was the only sound in the room, but it was a comforting reminder that her heart was still beating, that she was still here with him.

As the hours passed, Rahul couldn't stop staring at her. Her face, pale but serene, looked so peaceful as if she were just sleeping and would wake up any moment with that mischievous smile of hers. He leaned forward, resting his forehead against her hand, and whispered softly, "Naina, please come back to me. I need you. I love you more than you'll ever know."

The words came out in a rush, and for a moment, he couldn't breathe. He had never said them out loud before, at least not to her. But now, in the quiet of this room, it felt like the only truth he had ever known. He loved her, with every fiber of his being, and he couldn't bear the thought of a life without her.

Nitin, who had been sitting quietly in the corner, finally spoke. "Rahul, you need to rest, man. You've been here all night."

Rahul shook his head. "I can't leave her, Nitin. I won't."

Nitin sighed but didn't press the issue. He understood. Anyone who saw the way Rahul looked at Naina would understand. There was something unspoken between them, something that went beyond words or actions. It was the kind of love that made you feel like

you'd found a piece of yourself in another person, the kind of love that could break you but also heal you.

As the night wore on, Rahul found himself drifting off to sleep, his head resting on the edge of Naina's bed, his hand still holding hers. In his dreams, he saw her—laughing, running through fields of sunflowers, her hair flowing in the wind as she turned back to smile at him. It was so vivid, so real, that when he woke up in the early hours of the morning, he almost expected to see her standing there, waiting for him.

But she was still asleep, and the day dragged on painfully slow. Rahul stayed by her side, watching, waiting, hoping.

And then, in the late afternoon, he noticed the smallest movement. Her fingers twitched in his hand, and his heart leaped into his throat. "Naina?" he whispered, leaning closer. "Naina, can you hear me?"

Her eyelids fluttered, and for a moment, he thought he was imagining it. But then, slowly, painfully slowly, her eyes opened. They were glazed and unfocused at first, but when they finally settled on him, Rahul felt like the world had stopped turning.

"Rahul?" Her voice was barely more than a whisper, hoarse and weak, but it was the most beautiful sound he had ever heard.

He couldn't stop the tears that filled his eyes, his heart swelling with a mixture of joy and relief so intense it was almost painful.

"I'm here, Naina. I'm right here," he said, his voice thick with emotion. He gently cupped her face, his thumb brushing away a stray tear from her cheek. "You scared me," he whispered, his voice trembling. "You have no idea how scared I was."

Naina looked up at him, her eyes filled with a tenderness that made his chest ache. "I'm sorry," she said softly. "I didn't mean to."

Rahul laughed, a shaky, broken sound, but it was filled with relief. "Don't apologize. Just... don't ever do that to me again, okay?"

She gave him the faintest smile, and he could see the exhaustion in her eyes. But she was awake, and that was all that mattered. He kissed her hand, holding it tightly against his chest, as if he was afraid that if he let go, she might slip away again.

The doctor entered the room shortly after, checking her vitals and nodding approvingly. "She's doing well. She'll need to stay here for a few more days, but she's out of danger."

Rahul nodded, barely able to speak through the lump in his throat. When the doctor left, Naina turned to him, her eyes full of unspoken words. She looked fragile, weaker than he had ever seen her, but there was still a strength in her that amazed him.

"Rahul," she whispered, her voice still raspy from the ordeal. "Why are you crying?"

He hadn't even realized that the tears were still falling. "I thought I lost you," he said, his voice breaking as he struggled to hold back the sobs that were threatening to escape. "I didn't know what I would do if you didn't wake up."

Naina's eyes softened, and she reached out to touch his cheek, her thumb wiping away a tear. "I'm here," she said softly. "I'm not going anywhere."

Rahul leaned into her touch, closing his eyes as he felt the warmth of her hand against his skin. "I love you," he whispered, the words tumbling out before he could stop them. "I've loved you for so long, and I was too afraid to say it. But I can't keep it inside anymore. You're everything to me, Naina. I can't lose you."

Naina's eyes filled with tears, her lips trembling as she smiled at him. "I love you too," she whispered, her voice breaking. "I always have."

For a moment, the world seemed to stop. All the fear, all the pain of the past few days melted away, leaving only the two of them in the quiet of that hospital room. Rahul leaned in, resting his forehead against hers, their breaths mingling as they both cried, their hearts full of love and relief.

"I've waited so long to hear you say that," Rahul whispered, his voice shaking as he pressed a soft kiss to her forehead.

Naina smiled through her tears, her hand resting gently on his chest, feeling the steady beat of his heart. "I'm glad I finally said it."

The next few days passed in a blur of quiet moments and gentle touches. Rahul never left her side, and every night, he would sleep in the chair beside her, his hand resting in hers. They didn't need words. Their love was in the silence, in the way they looked at each other, in the way Rahul would brush her hair back from her face or bring her flowers every morning.

When Naina was finally discharged, they stepped out of the hospital together, hand in hand, the sun shining brightly overhead. It felt like a new beginning, a second chance at the life they had almost lost.

"Let's go to the coffee shop," Naina said suddenly, her eyes lighting up as she looked at him.

Rahul smiled. "The one we went to on our first date?"

She nodded, and without another word, they made their way to the little café where it had all begun. As they sat at their usual table, sipping their coffee, the weight of everything that had happened seemed to lift.

Naina reached across the table, taking his hand in hers, and for a moment, they just sat there, staring into each other's eyes, the world fading away.

"I'm so glad I have you," Naina whispered, her voice full of emotion. "I don't know what I would have done without you."

Rahul smiled, his heart swelling with love as he leaned across the table, brushing a soft kiss against her lips. "I'll always be here," he whispered, his voice full of quiet promise. "I'll never leave you."

Naina smiled, her eyes shining with unshed tears. "I know."

And as they sat there, holding each other's hands, lost in the quiet beauty of the moment, Rahul knew that they had found something rare, something precious. Their love was the kind that could weather any storm, the kind that would only grow stronger with time.

In that small café, surrounded by the soft hum of life going on around them, they kissed once more—a soft, tender kiss that spoke of everything they had been through and everything that was still to come.

It wasn't just a kiss. It was a vow, a promise to always be there for each other, no matter what.

As the sun set outside the window, painting the sky in shades of pink and gold, Rahul and Naina held each other close, their hearts beating as one, knowing that they had found their forever in each other's arms.

Last Chapter

Found but Lost

"Rahul... wake up... Rahul, wake up... please!"

He jolted awake, his heart pounding, the echo of Naina's voice still ringing in his ears. His eyes darted around, but all he saw was darkness. His mind was clouded and disoriented, still clinging to the hope that Naina was okay—that everything he had witnessed, her recovery, her smile, their love, had been real.

But slowly, reality came crashing down.

The waiting room. The hospital lights. The beeping monitors. It had all been a dream.

A dream.

Rahul sat up, gasping for breath as he realized he had been unconscious for only an hour or two. He hadn't even seen Naina after her surgery yet. His hands trembled as he touched his face, still wet with the tears from the dream. He looked at Nitin, who sat beside him, eyes heavy with concern.

"Rahul, you passed out. The doctor said you were just in shock, man. I tried waking you... but you were out for a couple of hours."

Nitin's voice was soft, but his words felt distant, like echoes in Rahul's head.

Rahul struggled to piece together what was real and what was imagined. The dream had felt so real—Naina waking up, their reunion, their shared smiles... but none of it had happened. His heart sank. He looked at Nitin with wide, confused eyes.

Rahul was still standing outside the operation theater, eyes heavy with worry, mind consumed with images of Naina. It had only been a minute since he woke up from the brief but overwhelming dream. For a few moments, Rahul stood motionless, his body frozen with a strange mix of hope and fear. His heart pounded in his chest, but he didn't listen to anyone around him. The world seemed distant, muffled, as if he were caught between two realities—the one where Naina had recovered, and the one where she was still fighting for her life.

Nitin nudged him gently, his voice low, "Rahul, you okay? You need some water, man."

Rahul didn't respond. He stared blankly at the closed doors of the operation theater, as if willing them to open and bring him good news. He didn't hear Nitin; he didn't hear anything. The sound of footsteps, the beeping machines in the hallway, even the murmured conversations of the doctors—all of it faded into the background as Rahul stood there, his entire world focused on that one door.

He stood up shakily, his legs weak beneath him. As he walked toward the ICU doors, the same doctor from his dream emerged, and reality hit him hard.

Then, suddenly, the doctor emerged, pulling off his mask with a look of exhaustion. He approached them, his face a mixture of relief and caution. "The surgery went well. She's stable now, out of danger, but she's still unconscious. She should wake up by tomorrow. We'll have to wait and see."

Hearing those words, relief washed over Rahul like a tidal wave. He gasped for air, his chest heaving as if he had been holding his breath for hours. Without thinking, he grabbed Nitin, hugging him tightly, his body trembling with a joy he couldn't contain. "She's okay... she's going to be okay!" Rahul repeated over and over, as if saying it enough times would make it more real.

Nitin, caught off guard by the sudden embrace, laughed through his own tears. "Yes, man! She's out of danger!"

Rahul couldn't stop smiling. He felt like the weight of the world had been lifted from his shoulders. He hugged Nitin again, and again—his relief overflowing into every action. For the first time in days, he felt light. The doctor gestured to a window that allowed them to see into Naina's room.

"You can see her," the doctor said kindly, "but just through the window for now. She's still recovering."

Rahul rushed to the window, pressing his hand against the glass, his eyes searching for Naina. There she was—pale, fragile, but alive. Machines beeped softly around her, tubes attached to her body, but none of that mattered to Rahul. All he saw was her chest rising and falling, the sign of life.

He placed his palm against the cold glass, his heart whispering words only he could hear. "Please... be okay. I love you, Naina. I love you."

Time passed in a blur. Rahul didn't leave the hospital. He couldn't. He stayed outside her room, watching through the window, unable to pull himself away. When evening came, the nurses allowed him to go inside for a moment. Rahul walked in quietly, his heart thumping in his chest. He knelt beside Naina's bed, but he didn't dare touch her. Instead, he sat on the cold floor, his head resting against the bed where she lay, his body close to hers, even though they were separated by the bed's metal frame.

He stayed like that all night, his eyes never leaving her face, his heart praying for her to wake up.

The next morning, sunlight streamed through the window, bathing the hospital room in a soft, warm glow. Rahul's eyes fluttered open. His neck was stiff from the awkward position he had slept in, but he didn't care. His gaze shifted immediately to Naina. And then... her eyes fluttered.

Rahul sat up straight, his heart pounding in his chest. "Naina... Naina?" he whispered, his voice trembling with hope.

Her eyelids opened slowly, and for a moment, Rahul's world stopped. She blinked, her eyes adjusting to the light, before slowly turning her head toward him.

"Naina! You're awake! You're okay!" Rahul's voice was filled with pure joy as he stood up, grabbing the bouquet of flowers he had bought earlier that morning. He placed it gently on the side table and leaned toward her, a smile spreading across his face. "I missed you so much... I was so worried... Are you okay?"

But Naina's face... something was wrong.

She looked at him with confusion, her brows furrowed as if she didn't understand what was happening. Rahul's smile faltered for a moment. "Naina? Are you okay? It's me... Rahul."

She didn't respond. Instead, she turned her head slightly, looking past him, toward her mother and father who were standing nearby. Her voice was weak, but she spoke, "Mom... Dad... my head hurts."

Her parents rushed to her side, relief flooding their faces as they kissed her forehead and whispered soothing words. But Naina... she didn't even glance at Rahul. She acted as if he wasn't there. Rahul stood frozen, his heart sinking slowly into his stomach. "Naina?" he tried again, stepping closer.

Naina's eyes shifted toward him, her face blank. Then, with the softest of voices, she asked, "Who... are you?"

The words hit Rahul like a punch to the gut. His mind raced. His heart stopped. The bouquet of flowers slipped from his hand, falling to the floor with a soft thud.

"I... it's me, Rahul," he stammered, his voice cracking. "We... we know each other. You don't remember me?"

Naina blinked at him, her confusion deepening. She glanced at her parents, but there was no recognition in her eyes when she looked back at him. "I'm... I'm sorry," she said slowly, her voice uncertain. "I don't know you."

Rahul felt like the ground was slipping away beneath his feet. His chest tightened as the doctor's earlier words echoed in his head—memory loss.

"No... this can't be happening," Rahul whispered under his breath. "This isn't real..."

He turned to the doctor, desperation in his eyes. "What's happening? Why doesn't she remember me? Please tell me this is temporary. Please!"

The doctor sighed, stepping forward. "It's likely due to the internal bleeding she suffered during the accident. Memory loss is common in these cases. It's possible she may not remember

events from the last few days, weeks, or even months. We can't be sure how much she's lost until she starts interacting more."

Rahul's world shattered in that moment. Every beautiful memory they had shared—their late-night talks, their walks in the park, their confessions of love—it was all gone, erased from her mind. Her father put a hand on Rahul's shoulder. "Rahul... I think it's best if you step outside for now. She needs rest."

Rahul wanted to scream, to protest, but he had no strength left. His body felt heavy, his mind numb. He nodded weakly and walked toward the door. As he reached for the handle, a nurse appeared, holding a small envelope.

"Excuse me," she said softly, "this was found with Naina when she was brought in. It might be important."

Rahul took the envelope, his fingers trembling as he looked at it. His name wasn't on it. There was no indication of who it was for. He hesitated for a moment, then slowly tore it open.

As he unfolded the letter, his eyes scanned the words—and with each sentence, the air seemed to leave his lungs. His hands shook violently as he read the final lines. His vision blurred with tears, and a single sob escaped his lips.

"What... what is this?" he whispered to himself, unable to comprehend what he was reading.

The letter—its contents—was not what Rahul had expected.

To be continued...

What was in that letter?

Who was it really for?

Did Naina truly lose her memory, or was there more to this story?

Could Rahul ever confess his love to Naina, and if so, how?

Find out in Part 2



"Love is not always about grand gestures or perfect moments. It's about being present in the imperfections, finding beauty in the flaws, and choosing to stay even when it's easier to walk away. This story is for anyone who has ever hesitated, doubted, or feared love, yet found the courage to embrace it anyway."

Om M Nandurkar

